



INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 01~08~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

Hotels are replacing Udaipur hills, policy framed by pvt agencies: HC

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, July 31

WHILE SLAMMING the Rajasthan government over the extent of the construction in the Aravalli Hills surrounding Udaipur, the Rajasthan High Court has said that its 2018 Hill Policy seemed to be authored by “certain private agencies”.

Expressing alarm over the hills being pushed to “the verge of extinction”, the High Court sought names of authors of the



Glaringly evident that hills and mountains have been brutally cut, says bench. FILE

state’s Hill Policy of 2018 and 2024, as well as the names and

designations of the top officers who had granted permissions for construction and commercial activities.

The court ironically was hearing the petition by a hotelier, Basant Hotels Private Ltd, that it had already attained due permissions under the 2018 policy, and that the provisions of the Hill Policy 2024 should not be applied to it.

A Bench of Justice Sameer Jain said last week — the order

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Udaipur

was uploaded Monday — that the court had perused the report prepared by the court-appointed court commissioners in the case, and “it is glaringly evident that the hills and mountains have been brutally cut and constructed upon until they are on the verge of extinction, effectively being replaced by hotels”.

Justice Jain added that it had come to the court’s knowledge that “the author and creator of the bye-laws vis-a-vis the Hill Policy 2018 were certain private external agencies”. “Shockingly, no advice or consultation was ever sought from the relevant statutory agencies and departments concerning climate, wild-life, pollution, and environment, either through the Union of India or the respective state departments,” he added.

The court also pointed out that an earlier PIL, by the Jheel Sanrakshan Samiti, had been closed based “entirely upon State undertakings and obligations that they would implement the Public Trust Doctrine”. “It is shocking to the conscience of the court that the State has instead authored a policy completely devoid of application of mind, expertise, or research and development, instigated merely by the support services of a private agency, and completely bypassing the Ministry of Environment, Climate, Wildlife, and Pollution Control Boards.”

Appearing for the Centre, Additional Solicitor General Bharat Vyas also said “Union of India, Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, and pollution control authorities were never consulted or made stakeholders in this policy”.

The High Court sought “complete details of all construction / commercial permissions granted in the nearby vicinity of the petitioner’s property”, along with the officers who granted the permissions as well as “the name of the author of the impugned Hill Policy of 2018 and author of the Hill Policy of 2024, along with all related primary documents”. The hill policy was being drafted by entities lacking any expertise, the court said, adding that while Articles 14 and 19 provide for equality and the freedom to carry out business and trade, these rights are “subject to

reasonable restrictions”.

The court demanded “the entire record pertaining to the creation of the said Hill policies, their rationale, and the private agency’s report”. “Under the guise of the sustainable development theory and arbitrarily crafted policies, hundreds of hotels, resorts, and commercial properties have mushroomed near sanctuaries, sensitive ecosystems, lakes, and upon the hills,” it said.

Lamenting the state of Udaipur, Justice Jain said “the city... renowned for its lakes, mountains/hills (Magris), and wildlife sanctuaries, has been reduced to a pitiable state”.

In its petition, Bastant Hotels Private Ltd said it had been in the business since 2007, had purchased land for construction in the Udaipur hills, and applied and received permissions for construction, conversion of land, building plan, and an adjoining road, etc.

The hotelier said they had taken a loan of Rs 20 crore and invested about Rs 12 crore in the said project, before the 2018 Hill Policy came into play under the previous Congress government. Then a PIL was filed and authorities were directed to seize their property and demolish it, Basant Hotelssaid. Its lawyer M S Singhvi argued that the provisions of the Hill Policy 2024 could not be applied to it as it had already attained due permissions under the policy of 2018.

During an earlier hearing, the court had noted that there were about 43 properties in the vicinity of Basant Hotels’ property, including hotels, resorts and residential houses, “and additionally certain mining activities are also prevailing”. The court had then appointed Advocate Kamini Joshi and retired IAS officer Rajendra Bhanawat as court commissioners.

The High Court is also hearing a PIL filed by the Jheel Sanrakshan Samiti, an organisation based in Udaipur, seeking quashing of the Hill Policy 24, constitution of a state-level Hill Conservation Authority, and re-framing of regulations “strictly in accordance with judicial directions, expert opinion and environmental principles”, and that no more expansion, extension, additional construction or increase in built-up area of existing structures in hill areas be permitted.

INDUSTRIES CITE RISING COSTS LINKED TO THE WEST ASIA CRISIS, SUPPLY CHAIN DELAYS

91% of industries in NCR fail to comply with emission norms, get 2 more months

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, July 31

MORE THAN 2,100 large or medium industrial units across Delhi-NCR, around 91% of such units across the region, have failed to comply with stricter particulate matter (PM) emission norms, including installation or retrofitting of air pollution control devices (APCDs), which were to come into force from August 1, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

This prompted the Commission for Air Quality Management in National Capital Region and Adjoining Areas (CAQM) on Thursday to defer the deadline by two months — until October 1 — after industries cited rising costs linked to the West Asia crisis, supply chain delays and shortage of technical agencies to assess existing systems.

200-odd units comply

Of the 2,321 industrial units identified for installation or retrofitting of APCDs, only around 200 had complied by July 31. The figure also included those pending verification, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The remaining 2,121 or 91.4% units had not complied with the order, officials said.

Industrial emissions in NCR are a precursor to secondary particulate matter, which, at 27%, has been identified as a major cause of winter pollution, followed by direct industrial emissions at 9%, according to CAQM records.

Air pollution control devices are industrial filtration systems installed on exhaust stacks to capture emissions. The primary technology used include Baghouses, which use fabric filters to trap over 99% of dust; Electrostatic Precipitators, which utilise high voltage electricity to collect charged particles from massive exhaust volumes; Cyclone Separators, affordable pre-filters that use centrifugal force to spin out coarse ash and Scrubbers, which wash out fine dust and toxic gases using liquid sprays or powders.

New deadline

The CAQM, through an amendment on Thursday postponed the implementation of the revised PM emission standard of 50 mg/Nm³ from August 1 to Oc-

INDUSTRIAL EMISSIONS AT A GLANCE

SOURCES

Furnaces, boilers, metal casting, refining operations, coal combustion, dry fly ash ponds, the burning of heavy oils

MAJOR CHALLENGES

A large number of unorganised units including plastic recycling and small-scale manufacturing operating in unauthorised or peripheral areas

Illegal burning of non-hazardous industrial waste along with fugitive emissions.

AIR QUALITY EXPERT panel set up



by CAQM in a February report stated that small-scale units utilise small boilers and furnaces and called for a transition to cleaner fuels

Challenges cited

Among the challenges flagged by industry associations was the prevailing geopolitical situation, which they said had imposed an additional financial burden on them.

Sources familiar with the discussions said manufacturers referred to disruptions arising from the ongoing West Asia crisis, which has increased costs and affected the procurement of components needed for pollution control equipment. According to the order, industries cited long delay in the supply of air pollution control devices, limited availability of agencies to carry out technical adequacy assessments of existing systems, and a shortage of laboratories recognised under the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986, to verify compliance with the revised emission standards. These factors had slowed installation, retrofitting and certification of across the region.

While industry associations had sought an extension ranging from three months to one pollution season, the CPCB recommended extending the timeline until October 1, said officials.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 tober 1 for the identified industries.

It said the decision followed recommendations of the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) and representations from industries and associations.

The commission had identified 17 categories of high-polluting industries –including food processing units, textiles with boilers and metal furnaces, among others – ordering them to cap PM emissions at 50 mg/Nm³, down from the

previous 80 mg/Nm³. While large or medium plants had to comply by this limit – based on CPCB and Indian Institute of Technology (IIT)-Kanpur studies – by August, smaller units had to follow suit by October.

The CAQM said that the revised emission limit remains "technically feasible and environmentally necessary", and acknowledged that industries had faced practical constraints in meeting the deadline.

LS CLEARS REGISTRATION OF BIRTHS & DEATHS (AMENDMENT) BILL, 2026 BY VOICE VOTE

Ruckus in both Houses as Opp keeps heat on Govt over police crackdown

You are in Emergency mood, don't want to listen to anyone: RS Chairman to Opp

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 31

AMID PROTESTS and sloganeering by Opposition MPs against police crackdown during the July 20 'Sansad Chalo' march who also demanded the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah, the Lok Sabha on Friday passed the Registration of Births and Deaths (Amendment) Bill, 2026 by a voice vote as Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju expressed displeasure over the Opposition's disruption.

When Lok Sabha reconvened at 11 am, Opposition MPs raised slogans and demanded that Shah come to the House and explain the police action on protesters. Speaker Om Birla urged them to return to their seats and allow the Question Hour as many of them had trooped into the Well. However, as the ruckus continued, it was adjourned for an hour.

The House sat again at noon and MoS (Home) Nityanand

Rai moved the Registration of Births and Deaths (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which seeks to amend provisions of the Registration of Births and Deaths Act, 1969, to encourage timely reporting of vital events. Opposition MPs continued to protest and amid the din, the Bill was passed without discussion.

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said, "It is unfortunate that no Opposition MP took part in the discussion ... People who sent you to Parliament will seek answers from you ... then you go out and say that Bills are being passed without discussion. You have been sent to the House for discussion, not for *hungama* (ruckus)." Soon after the Bill's passage, LS was adjourned for the day.

The Bill seeks to make delayed registration of births and deaths more stringent by requiring an order from a judicial magistrate (first class) for registrations made more than two years after the event.

In Rajya Sabha, as the Zero



Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju in LS on Friday. PTI

Hour commenced and papers were laid on the table, several Opposition MPs were on their feet demanding that LoP Mallikarjun Kharge be allowed to speak. Vice President and Chairman C P Radhakrishnan said that the Opposition was still in "Emergency mood".

Radhakrishnan said he had allowed Kharge to speak previously as well though he thought the point of order was not valid. "Every time I am yielding to LoP but you are not listening to others. Is that correct? That will not strengthen democracy... You are in Emergency

mood till today, you want everybody to listen, but you don't want to listen to anyone."

He later permitted Kharge to speak, but ruled that no notices under Rule 267 will be admitted after the LoP sought to raise some issues under the provision. The LoP notice under Rule 267 pertained to the alleged fund misappropriation and irregularities in land acquisition for Ram temple.

Opposition MPs raised slogans against the government over alleged paper leaks, and also demanded that Shah come to the House. The Chairman, however, said, "What does the Home Minister have to do with the Zero Hour?" Opposition has been seeking a statement from the Home Minister on police action on protesters on July 20, including the use of pellet guns.

Speaking in RS Thursday, Kharge questioned the use of force against students and demanded Shah's resignation.

With Opposition MPs raising slogans, Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan accused them of indulging in "sadak-chhap (crass)" politics. "They just want to create drama and they don't really want to have a discussion."

SIR: At 16.3%, Haryana records 3rd-highest deletion in draft stage

Express News Service
Chandigarh, New Delhi, July 31

THE DRAFT roll of Haryana's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) published on Friday showed 16.39% deletions, the third-highest among states where the exercise has been held so far.

Only Arunachal Pradesh, where the draft SIR electoral roll was published on July 21, and Uttar Pradesh, where the drive was completed in April this year, have recorded higher deletions in the draft stage at 19.09% and 18.7% respectively.

According to a statement released by the state's Chief Electoral Officer, 83.61% of the state's registered voters had submitted their enumeration forms, making it to the draft roll. The remaining 16.39% electors were marked shifted/absent/others, deceased and enrolled at multiple places, leading to their deletion from the draft roll.

Currently, the third phase of the SIR is on in 16 states and three UTs, with 10 states and three UTs having completed the exercise so far. The draft roll of Andhra Pradesh was also published Friday, showing 10.78% deletions.

Data released by the Haryana Election Department shows that "as on July 24, 2026, out of 2,06,55,929 electors, a total of 1,72,72,627 electors have submitted their Enumeration Forms, reflecting overwhelming participation during the Enumeration Phase of SIR", which is approximately 83.6% of the state's total electorate.

According to officials, "as part of the exercise, BLOs carried out door-to-door verification of registered voters across the state. The department described the campaign as one of the most comprehensive voter verification exercises in the state's history. Real Creator IAS Edition https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F

Electoral Roll Call

In Haryana

- Enumeration Forms collected: **1.72 crore (83.61%)**
- Permanently Shifted/Absent /Others electors: **24.13 lakh (11.68%)**
- Deceased: **7.66 lakh (3.71%)**
- Enrolled at Multiple Places: **2.04 lakh (0.99%)**

SOURCE: ELECTION COMMISSION OF INDIA

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

tion drives undertaken so far".

During the verification process, 24.13 lakh voters, representing 11.68% of the electorate, could not be traced at their registered addresses. According to the election department, many of these individuals had relocated to another city or state, had been absent for an extended period, or failed to submit their enumeration forms within the stipulated timeframe.

The exercise also revealed that 7.66 lakh voters, or 3.71% of the electorate, were deceased. In addition, 2.04 lakh voters, accounting for 0.99% of the electorate, were found to have their names registered in the electoral rolls of two or more constituencies.

Election officials said after verification of documents, such voters will be allowed to retain their registration at only one location, while duplicate entries will be removed.

The Election Department emphasised that the objective of the SIR is not merely to enroll new voters but to create a clean, reliable and up-to-date electoral roll by removing the names of deceased, migrated and duplicate voters. The revised voter list will serve as the basis for conducting the upcoming elections.

The department also clarified that the exercise is a

Top 5 states in deletions at draft stage

States	Deletions
Arunachal Pradesh	19.09%
Uttar Pradesh	18.70%
Haryana	16.39%
Tamil Nadu	15.19%
Gujarat	14.50%

fied that voters whose names have been omitted or whose enumeration forms could not be collected need not be concerned.

A claims and objections period will be held from July 31 to August 30, 2026, during which eligible citizens can submit applications along with the required documents. During this period, voters will be able to apply for inclusion of their names, request deletions or corrections, or file objections against any entry in the electoral roll. A total of 90 EROs and 1,601 AEROs will be scrutinising such cases.

According to the Election Department, all claims and objections received during the designated period will undergo detailed scrutiny before a final decision is taken. Only after this verification process is completed will the final electoral roll be published.

"The successful completion of the enumeration phase is the result of coordinated efforts of District Election Officers of all 23 districts, 90 EROs, 1,594 AEROs, 2,244 BLO Supervisors and 20,629 BLOs deployed at 20,629 polling stations, supported by volunteers," the Election Commission said in a release issued this evening.

Jaishankar to Iran's Araghchi: No matter what, do not attack merchant vessels

Divya A
New Delhi, July 31

A DAY after the government informed Parliament that 16 Indian nationals, including 10 seafarers, had been killed and another 75 injured in West Asia since the start of the conflict in February, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar spoke to his Iranian counterpart Syed Abbas Araghchi Friday and "strongly urged" Iran to avoid attacks on commercial shipping and seafarers under any circumstances.

Jaishankar's phone conversation with Araghchi came a day after he conveyed India's concern over attacks on cargo vessels and seafarers to Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha

"Had a tele-conversation with FM Araghchi of Iran this evening. Conveyed our deep concerns at the ongoing hostilities in the region," Jaishankar said after the conversation.

"Strongly urged that attacks on commercial shipping and seafarers be avoided under any circumstance," he said in a post on X, adding, "India condemns any such attack by any party."

"Was apprised of Iran's perspective of current developments and discussions under-

way," Jaishankar said, underlining that "India is always supportive of dialogue and diplomacy".

Over the past few days, New Delhi has expressed deep worry over a spate of attacks on merchant vessels in the Strait of Hormuz and the Black Sea, which have resulted in the death of Indian seafarers. It has condemned such actions by any party in the conflict.

This is the first time India has framed such a strong response and conveyed it to all parties concerned, having lost 10 seafarers in the West Asia conflict in attacks by either Iran or the US.

MoS for External Affairs Kirti Vardhan Singh told Rajya Sabha Thursday that 16 Indian nationals, including 10 seafarers, were killed and another 75 injured in the West Asia conflict since February.

On July 14, the Ministry of External Affairs had summoned Iranian Deputy Chief of Mission, Mohammad Javed Hosseini, to register a "strong protest" after an Indian sailor died and several were seriously injured when two UAE-flagged energy tankers carrying Indian seafarers were hit by Iranian cruise missiles earlier in the day.

Robust conflict of interest policy in place: Govt on selecting firms for RDI funds

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 31

THE SELECTION of companies for receiving money from newly created Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) Fund followed "robust evaluation mechanisms", "strict conflict of interest guidelines" and "merit-based selection processes", Ministry of Science & Technology said in a statement on Friday.

This came a day after Science and Technology Minister Jitendra Singh said in a written reply in RS that 7 of 11 members of one of the selection panels had a personal investment in several of companies that had been selected for receiving funds under RDI scheme.

On Friday, the ministry said that no member of the selection panel participated in evaluation of any company in which they had a personal interest. Any such interest was disclosed in advance, in accordance with the conflict of interest policy, it said.

"A comprehensive and robust Conflict of Interest policy is firmly in place at TDB (Technology Development Board, one of the fund managers responsible for disbursement of money from RDI fund). This policy has been followed systematically over a long period..." the ministry statement said. "Prior to the commencement of the 1st Investment Committee meeting (investment committee acts as the selection panel), TDB framed detailed Pre-Investment Guidelines/SoPs. These guidelines explicitly lay down the conditions under which a potential conflict of interest arises. Whenever a member has a potential conflict, the policy mandates full disclosure and complete recusal of concerned member from all discussions and decision-making processes regarding that entity."

All funding decisions were taken on merit as per Implementation Guidelines of RDI Fund, with zero involvement of conflicted members during evaluation or sanction process, it said.

In a 1st, Manipur CM meets Zomi groups in Imphal

MANIPUR CM Yumnam Khemchand Singh Friday met representatives of three major Zomi organisations from Imphal's Churachandpur, marking the first such meeting since ethnic violence erupted in the state in 2023. The 14-member delegation included representatives of Unified Zou Organisation, Zomi Chiefs Association and Zomi Council. The delegation briefed the CM on issues affecting the state and expressed support for government's efforts to restore peace and normalcy. ENS

• UNLESS STATES BECOME ENGINES OF EDUCATIONAL REFORMS, INNOVATION & ENTREPRENEURSHIP RATHER THAN MERE PRODUCERS OF DEGREE-HOLDERS, GAPS BETWEEN ASPIRATIONS & OPPORTUNITIES WILL ONLY WIDEN

Exam leaks to education revolution: Why states have task cut out, Punjab to HP



NORTHERN LIGHTS
BY MANRAJ GREWAL SHARMA

A WEEKLY DISPATCH ON THE POLITICS AND IDEAS SHAPING NORTH INDIA

WHILE IT may have been triggered by the NEET-UG exam paper leak, the Jantar Mantar agitation of students and youths has brought education to the centre of conversations in drawing rooms across India besides making it a recurring theme in current political discourse.

In Punjab, education emerged as a major plank in the 2022 Assembly polls when the AAP swept the state on its twin promises of “*badlav* (change)” and “*sikhya kranti* (education revolution)”. The then AAP-led

Delhi government's perceived success in revamping government schools there resonated with the Punjab voters long accustomed to spending heavily on private schools whose main selling point has been the “English-medium” label. Even today, education remains one of the Bhagwant Mann-led AAP government's key political USPs.

The neighbouring Himachal Pradesh has also traditionally enjoyed an enviable record in school education. It was among the first states in North India to achieve near-universal literacy, with literacy rising from 63.9% in 1991 to over 99% in 2025. Its success rested on early political commitment, geography-adapted systems and strong community ownership.

Founding Himachal chief minister YS Parmar was known to trek from village to village, equipped with a typewriter, so he could sanction a school wherever he found a habitation. High male migration boosted female literacy, while parent-teacher associations and panchayats kept teachers on their

toes. More recently, CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu sought to sustain the momentum by directing deputy commissioners to adopt government schools.

Punjab has continued to bask in the success of its school-focused initiatives. Education Minister Harjot Singh Bains says the state has climbed from 27th place in 2020 to first rank in the NITI Aayog's Education Quality Report 2026 after the AAP government, he added, raised the education budget by 50%, recruited more teachers and sent them for training to Singapore and Finland.

Government school students also topped the 2024 PARAKH Rashtriya Sarvekshan held by NCERT, while the number of NEET qualifiers from the government schools has risen from about 80 before 2022 to 882 in 2026. Punjab has become the first state to introduce AI as a subject from Class I. Yet, education is not just a collection of disparate institutions but an integrated pipeline linking schools with competitive exams and universities, which in turn feed the la-



Congress MPs Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, Amar Singh, Gurjeet Singh Aujla and Dharamvira Gandhi protest outside Parliament. ANI

bour market. Failures at any stage undermine the system.

In Punjab, the Opposition leaders have alleged leaks even as the Mann government denies any pre-exam breach. The latest exam row erupted after police busted an inter-state cheating racket during the pharmacy officer recruitment exam.

Haryana, too, has faced repeated allegations of exam malpractices, while Himachal's 2022 police recruitment paper leak eventually led to a CBI probe, over 170 arrests and dissolution

of the Staff Selection Commission. The Sukhu government has since enacted one of India's toughest anti-paper leak laws, with punishments of up to 10-year jail term and a fine of up to Rs 1 crore. Any paper leak, however small, is an outrage because it erodes common people's trust in the promise of meritocracy.

In these three states, which continue to witness large-scale migration of their youths — Haryana has even set up a bureau to facilitate overseas employment — every paper leak,

whether local or national, becomes another push factor. While these states have invested heavily in schools, higher education has increasingly been outsourced to private universities with gleaming campuses and equally steep fees.

Punjab can count its quality public universities on the fingers of one hand. All the state's leading public varsities were set up over 5 decades ago. Panjab University was established in 1882, while Punjabi University and Punjab Agricultural University were founded in 1962. Guru Nanak Dev University came into existence in 1969. Today, these institutions soldier on despite chronic financial constraints. The explosion of private universities over the past two decades — Punjab is home to 21 such campuses, while Haryana and Himachal account for 25 and 17 respectively, as per the UGC — has not necessarily led to better educational outcomes.

The problem is not merely rooted in access but also connected with quality. The region has yet to build a robust eco-

system of research, innovation and industry collaboration. India spends about 0.8% of its GDP on research and development, well below most innovation-driven economies. Many universities thus remain teaching institutions rather than the centres of discovery and excellence. More campuses do not automatically translate into more patents, start-ups or globally competitive graduates.

These challenges come at a critical moment. With a median age of about 29 years, India enjoys one of the world's youngest populations. But demographic dividends are realised only when education leads to productivity. Otherwise, it may become a demographic burden. For Punjab, Haryana and Himachal, affected by rampant out-migration, the stakes could not be higher. And then, there is a crisis of unemployment which has been a constant refrain among employers, reflected in shrinking campus placements. For many parents spending heavily on their children's education, the results of their efforts have

increasingly become uncertain.

The Haryana government under the previous CM, Manohar Lal Khattar, had tried to introduce a 75% quota for locals in the private sector through a legislation, with an eye on Gurgaon which attracts investment and talent. The 2020 law was struck down by the Punjab and Haryana High Court in 2023. The NEP is being projected as part of a solution through an emphasis on vocational education. But skills alone can't create start-ups if the ecosystem is not conducive to enterprise. Unless the states become engines of educational reforms, innovation and entrepreneurship rather than merely producers of degree-holders, the gaps between aspirations and opportunities will only widen.

In the final analysis, a paper leak does not just betray a compromised exam, it exposes the gaps between an education system that teaches or tests and one that delivers opportunities. Bridging those gaps, not merely plugging leaks, would mark the real education revolution the states in the region must deliver.



‘Will take partnership to new heights’: PM Modi speaks to UK counterpart

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 31

AFTER HIS first call with newly elected UK Prime Minister Andy Burnham, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday said that both countries would strengthen cooperation across technology, defence and security sectors, while also taking the recently operationalised India-UK Comprehensive Strategic Partnership to new heights.

In a post on X, PM Modi said he was delighted to speak with

the UK PM and congratulated him on assuming office.

“We agreed to work together across sectors such as technology, innovation, defence, security, clean energy, education and people-to-people ties and take the India-UK Comprehensive Strategic Partnership to new heights,” he said. “We will also collaborate closely to fully harness the trade and investment opportunities presented by the recently operationalised India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement, for the

shared prosperity and well-being of both our people.”

According to the statement from the UK Government, Burnham — who took over as PM on July 20 — discussed the strength of the UK-India partnership. The leaders also exchanged views on the situation in West Asia and agreed to continue working closely towards de-escalation and the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, it said.

“The PM began by reflecting on the strength of the UK-India partnership and the

significant impact it has had on local communities across the UK. The PM set out his ambitions to further enhance the UK-India relationship, including through the UK-India Vision 2035 framework and strong people-to-people links.”

Burnham also underlined the potential of the India-UK CETA and noted that this will create opportunities for people in both countries. Both Prime Ministers expressed their desire to continue discussions and meet in person at the earliest opportunity.

Cauvery: DKS defers meeting with Vijay, calls all-party meet on Aug 2

Express News Service
Bengaluru, July 31

A DAY after the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) endorsed a directive of the Cauvery Water Regulatory Committee (CWRC) to Karnataka to release 3,500 cusecs of water to Tamil Nadu, the D K Shivakumar government deferred the August 3 meeting with Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Vijay Joseph, called an all-party meeting on August 2 on the issue and pro-Kannada groups announced a state bandh on August 13.

Despite Karnataka’s request to the CWMA to delay the implementation of a CWRC order dated July 28 by a fortnight, the Authority on Thursday upheld the CWRC order and directed the Karnataka government to immediately release water to Tamil Nadu for 15 days.

The CWMA order is the first Cauvery crisis encountered by the two new CMs of Karnataka and Tamil Nadu — D K Shivakumar and C Joseph Vijay — whose parties are political allies.

Pro-Kannada groups, which have traditionally been against



Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar chairs a meeting in the wake of CWMA order, in Bengaluru on Friday. ^{PTI}

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(CWRC) order to release water to Tamil Nadu must be strongly opposed. There will be a bandh in the whole of Karnataka on August 13 from 6 am to 6 pm. The Karnataka Film Association, the state employees association, hotel associations and others are supporting this bandh. We call for moral support from everyone and ask that no one should oppose the bandh,” said veteran Kannada activist Vatal Nagaraj.

Earlier this week, Karnataka CM Shivakumar had invited Vijay to the state for a meeting on the Cauvery issue on August 3 and suggested a joint aerial survey to understand the water cri-

sis due to a deficient Monsoon.

On Friday, Shivakumar said the meeting with Vijay was postponed. “It was decided that the Tamil Nadu CM would come on August 3. The situation is not good now... If they intend to protect the interests of their state, we intend to protect the interests of our state...” he said.

On Thursday, following the CWMA’s confirmation of the CWRC July 28 order, the Karnataka CM said another appeal had been filed before the Authority and an all-party meeting on the Cauvery water issue will be held on Sunday, August 2.

“We have discussed this issue with (BJP) MPs and Union Min-

E. EXPLAINED

No mechanism for distress years

The contention of political parties in Karnataka and Tamil Nadu is that Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal and the Supreme Court order on sharing of Cauvery water have only spelt out the norms during normal Monsoon and not distress years. The parties have in the past called for the PM’s intervention to create a mechanism for redressal of the dispute in distress years.

isters Pralhad Joshi, V Somanna, Jagadish Shettar and Basavaraj Bommai, and they are making utmost efforts for the welfare of the state,” Shivakumar said.

“The entire country must work together,” he said regarding the possibility of tensions escalating on the issue with the Opposition parties in the two states looking to capitalise on the quandary of the allies.

Cabinet clears 5-yr extension for PM-KISAN

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 31

THE CENTRE on Friday approved continuation of the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi (PM-KISAN) Scheme for the next five years. A decision of this effect was taken during the Cabinet meeting chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

According to an official statement issued after the Cabinet meeting, the PM-KISAN will continue for the next five years from 2026-27 to 2030-31. “A total financial outlay of Rs.3.15 lakh crore has been approved for the Scheme during this period,” it said.

“The approval reiterates the Government’s commitment that the prosperity of farmers forms the foundation of the nation’s prosperity. Through the PM-KISAN Scheme, timely and transparent income support is being provided to eligible farmer families through the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) system, enabling farmers to increase agricultural investment and strengthen their livelihoods,” the statement said.

The scheme was launched on February 24, 2019, ahead of the Lok Sabha elections.

NSA invoked by Assam against activist day after he gets bail

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, July 31

A DAY after a local court granted bail to land rights activist Pranab Doley, who was arrested on July 12 in connection with protests against a proposed luxury hotel project in Kaziranga, the Assam government invoked the National Security Act (NSA) against him, stating that his activities “are prejudicial to the maintenance of public order as well as security of the state”.

Doley is a prominent indigenous and land rights activist who was arrested by the Golaghat police in connection with June 28 protest against a proposed luxury hotel project in Inglay Pathar, adjoining the

Kaziranga National Park. Four other activists were also arrested in connection with this. Doley has been leading protests for years, raising concerns about potential ecological impact of the project and displacement of indigenous villagers.

In its FIR, police alleged Doley and “about fifty other persons” “trespassed” to the project site “with pre-planned manner, being armed with deadly weapons like machete, sharp sticks, etc”, assaulted police personnel, “instigated the crowd” and “threatened” further agitation, among other allegations.

In a July 29 order granting bail to Doley, an Additional Sessions Judge in Golaghat observed that there is prima facie

absence of footage demonstrating these allegations and no “deadly weapon” was seized during investigation.

While Doley was still in the district jail, the state government issued an order for his preventive detention under the NSA, citing a report by the SSP of Golaghat.

The order states that the government “has considered the nature, gravity, frequency and potential consequences of the activities attributed to the detainee and is satisfied that there is a real and imminent possibility of the detainee continuing to indulge in activities prejudicial to the maintenance of public order and security of the State, if he is not prevented from doing so.”

The release of Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu during distress years for Karnataka farmers, held a meeting on Friday afternoon and announced a state bandh on August 13.

“The

MAHAGENCO'S COAL MINE

SC: Fresh public hearing must for clearance, but mining to continue

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 31

THE SUPREME Court has held that a fresh public consultation was required before granting the Environmental Clearance (EC) for Maharashtra State Power Generation Company Limited's (MAHAGENCO) Gare Palma Sector-II coal mine in Chhattisgarh. But there would be no restriction, the court clarified, on the company's mining activities "merely because the requisite fresh public consultation has not been undertaken so far".

The judgment, delivered on July 24 by a Bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, was uploaded subsequently.

The EC for the Gare Palma Sector-II Coal Mine was granted to MAHAGENCO in July 2022. The grant of EC was challenged before the National Green Tribunal (NGT), which, in January 2024, quashed the EC after noting deficiencies in the appraisal process and directed the Environment Ministry to "re-examine the matter from the stage of conducting public consultation afresh".

Following the NGT's order, MAHAGENCO resubmitted the project for appraisal, the ministry's Expert Appraisal Committee (EAC) reconsidered it, and a fresh EC was granted in August 2024, without conducting a fresh public hearing.

The fresh EC was also challenged before the NGT. In its order dated April 17, the NGT upheld the EC, observing that the appraisal process had re-

considered the earlier public hearing through videography, records and further examination by the authorities.

The petitioners challenged the NGT's order before the Supreme Court, which held that the expression "afresh" used in the NGT's earlier order required the authorities to undertake a fresh public consultation.

The Bench observed: "In our considered opinion, the expression 'afresh' connotes that it was obligatory upon the authorities to conduct afresh public consultation. Since such an exercise has not been carried out, the contrary view taken by the NGT in the impugned judgment does not seem to be sustainable."

However, the court clarified that MAHAGENCO's mining operations need not be halted solely on account of the pending fresh public consultation "since substantial compliance has already taken place".

The July 24 order said: "It is clarified that there shall not be any impediment to respondent No. 4 (MAHAGENCO) merely because the requisite fresh public consultation has not been undertaken so far. At the same time, we have no doubt that 'afresh public consultation' ought to have been undertaken before the grant of EC."

Accordingly, the SC remitted the matter to the NGT, directing it to monitor completion of the fresh public consultation process and pass an appropriate order thereafter. The NGT was directed to take up the matter on August 3 and decide it expeditiously.

Allahabad HC judge recuses self from hearing bail

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, July 31

OBSERVING THAT the incident marked a 'black day in the history of the court', Justice Krishan Pahal of the Allahabad High Court has recused himself from hearing dozens of bail pleas after litigants attempted to approach the judge during the pendency of the matters.

The single-judge bench of Justice Pahal was hearing one of the 75 bail applications of the accused lodged in jail since 2025 facing multiple cases in the al-

leged cough syrup smuggling racket, originating from UP and spread across various states and nations bordering India.

Remarking that such conduct strikes at the very heart of judicial independence, the judge directed that all the 75 pleas be placed before the Chief Justice of Allahabad HC for assignment to an appropriate bench.

The remarks came while the court was hearing the bail application of Bhola Prasad Jaiswal, father of the fugitive kingpin of the codeine-based syrup racket Shubham Jaiswal.

The court stated in its order passed on July 30, "...this Court had fixed all the matters to be heard today finally and order might have been delivered at a later point of time. Subsequently, efforts were made by the litigating parties to secure access to and approach the Presiding Judge. Such conduct, if permitted to pass unnoticed, strikes at the very heart of judicial independence and erodes public confidence in the purity of the adjudicatory process."

The bench of Justice Pahal observed, "This Court records,

with profound anguish and an abiding sense of institutional responsibility, that the present episode marks a black day in the history of this Court. The very edifice of the judicial institution rests upon the unwavering confidence of the public that justice is administered impartially, fearlessly, and without any extraneous influence. Any attempt, however subtle or clandestine, to interfere with or influence the judicial decision-making process constitutes a direct assault upon the majesty of the Rule of Law."

Blinded by pellets in 2016, J&K woman gets her Rs 41-lakh due

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, July 31

A DAY after the J&K government approved the release of compensation in her favour, Insha Mushtaq, one of Kashmir's youngest pellet victims from the 2016 unrest, said that the weapon "should never be used anywhere in India because pellets destroy lives".

Insha was 15 when she was blinded, three days after the killing of Hizbul Mujahideen's Burhan Wani. There were protests in her village of Sedow, and she had opened the window of her home to see the commotion outside when scores of pellets hit her face. She also suffered fractures to her face and skull.

An LPG distributorship was sanctioned in her favour in 2018, but the funds were not released as the PDP-BJP government fell and soon after, the Assembly was dissolved.

"Justice delayed but not denied. Insha Mushtaq lost her eyesight to pellets in 2016; her LPG distributorship was sanctioned in 2018 but left incomplete. Under Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, we have approved the release of the Rs 41.16 lakh balance to finally

take this case to its logical conclusion," J&K Food and Civil Supplies minister Satish Sharma announced.

On Friday, Sharma told *The Indian Express* that when the assistance was announced for Insha during the previous government, about Rs 20 lakh had been released to her for this agency, but the balance of over Rs 41 lakh has been cleared just now. "This was not done under any government scheme or programme; we have made special provision for her," he said.

"Pellets should never be used anywhere in India because they destroy lives..." Insha said Friday. She said that thousands have suffered like her in Kashmir and "pellets should be banned." Having undergone a lot of difficulties adjusting to a new life without her sight, Insha said, "I used to think I would not be able to do anything with my life. God helped me, and my parents motivated me to push forth in life."

In 2018, Insha cleared her Class 10 exam with the help of a scribe. She is currently in the final year of her bachelor's degree. "I fought this over the last ten years, and it was a struggle, but now I am grateful for where I am," she said.



Farmers need income, not price support

THE MADHYA Pradesh government has seemingly pacified agitating farmers with the assurance that it will procure 60 per cent of their estimated summer moong (green gram) produce, up from the existing 25 per cent limit. This comes even as the crop — sown during March to early-April and harvested by mid-June — is wholesaling in mandis at about Rs 7,000 per quintal, as against the minimum support price (MSP) of Rs 8,768. MP farmers, like those in other states, want the government’s declared MSPs to be not just on paper. The MP government was willing to pay the MSP for up to 1.2 quintals yield per acre, which it has now raised to 3 quintals. Farmers harvesting 6-8 quintals, twice the assessed state average, stand to lose the most on their extra yield sold below the MSP.

The demand for MSP as an entitlement is being voiced today by farmers not only in Punjab and Haryana, or those growing rice and wheat. In this case, it is from farmers cultivating crops that aren’t as water and fertiliser-guzzling and also in which the country is significantly import-dependent. A guaranteed MSP for pulses and oilseeds has economic justification, too, especially if it induces the desired acreage shifts in their favour from surplus cereals and sugarcane. But there is a heavy fiscal cost. MP — for that matter, any other state government — clearly does not have the resources to procure and stock all the moong or soyabean brought by farmers for selling at MSP. Governments can, at best, pay the difference between the MSP and the lower market price for the quantity of crops sold in the mandis. Such payment of price difference is preferable even in rice and wheat, where government agencies are holding stocks in excess of the requirements of the public distribution system and welfare schemes.

But neither physical procurement at MSP nor payment of price difference can be a sustainable solution in the interest of Indian agriculture and farmers themselves. Farmers need income, not price support. Once assured of an MIP — minimum income support in the form of a per-acre direct transfer — they will produce those crops that the market wants. Agricultural policy should focus on enabling them to do that by complementing, rather than displacing and distorting markets. MIP, with crop insurance and more public investment in agricultural research and rural infrastructure, is the best support the government can give to Indian farmers. MSPs and input subsidies have been ineffective at best, and market-distorting and fiscally ruinous at worst.

A tough road to Hamas disarmament

WHETHER US President Donald Trump’s announcement of the “complete disarmament” of Hamas and other armed groups in Gaza proves to be the breakthrough he claims it will be depends on all parties honouring their commitments. The US President has said Hamas’s disarmament would pave the way for a Palestinian committee to take over governance in Gaza and for Israel’s military withdrawal, as envisaged under his 20-point peace plan, which Hamas and Israel agreed to nearly 10 months ago. That Hamas will agree to disarm is, based on current evidence, highly improbable. Whatever legitimacy it still commands is rooted in its use of terror as resistance against Israel’s illegal occupation.

The first challenge is one of sequencing: Who makes the first concession? Shortly after Trump’s announcement, Hamas said it would not move on disarmament before Israel withdraws from the Strip. The second concerns the weapons. Hamas says it has agreed to transfer its arsenal to the National Committee for the Administration of Gaza (NCAG), a body of independent Palestinian technocrats supervised by the Board of Peace. Israel has maintained that the “full demilitarisation” of Gaza is a “non-negotiable” precondition for any military withdrawal. Indeed, the 13 members of the NCAG have so far been barred by Israel from entering Gaza. Matters are further complicated by opposition from Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s right-wing allies, who have gone beyond the government’s stated war aims by advocating permanent Israeli security control over Gaza and the re-establishment of Jewish settlements there. How far Netanyahu, with an eye on the next election, is willing — or able — to override them will depend on the pressure Trump is prepared to exert him.

Despite the ceasefire, Israel has continued to carry out airstrikes, while the humanitarian catastrophe unleashed by the war following Hamas’s October 7 terror attack has shown little sign of abating. Israel continues to restrict the entry of humanitarian aid into the Strip, and making the survival of the civilian population contingent on Hamas’s disarmament amounts to collective punishment. Whatever the fate of Trump’s peace plan, food, medicine and infrastructure material must be allowed to make their way to Gaza, and reconstruction must begin without delay. That should not be hijacked by either Israel or Hamas.

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YOUTH ARE future-looking, the proverbial canaries in the coal-mine. Their frustrations, simmering for years as they sit exam after exam in an often futile search for seats in elite educational institutions or government jobs, have finally boiled over. As our youth lit up social media, and fearlessly endured police lathis, tear gas, and FIRs, they captured the public’s imagination. The government eventually conceded protester demands and set up a high-powered task force on examination reform under the respected Nandan Nilekani. Even so, there is a real risk we miss the signal our youth are sending.

They are not just concerned about exam leaks, as this newspaper has itself pointed out. Their fears are partly about joblessness: About a future made bleak by inadequate education and skilling, the spread of artificial intelligence and automation, and competition from countries with better-prepared workforces. Official figures already put unemployment among 15–29-year-olds at more than three times the overall rate.

They also worry the government has done too little to change the current trajectory, which has yielded too few good jobs, even while it constantly celebrates an ambitious target — becoming a developed country by 2047 — as if we were already there. They see little willingness to listen to criticism, with messengers quickly labelled “anti-national”. As a university student told me, “the system does not listen to its people, and has no sense of what is going wrong”. A broader unease about authoritarianism, divisiveness, cronyism and corruption also ran through protester memes and interviews.

Not every issue is as amenable to mass

mobilisation as is access to higher education. Moreover, India needs to tackle root concerns, not only symptoms like exam leaks. An organised Opposition must carry those concerns into public debate and force those in power to confront unwelcome facts. Without such pressure, governments have little incentive to correct course.

An Opposition cannot only oppose, it needs to propose. It needs a plan to better the government’s plan. The plan must sway minds but also touch hearts. Our Opposition leaders have alternative views to the government’s, some mirroring those of our youth leaders, but they need to articulate them with more coherence, consistency, and clarity, and back them with actions wherever possible.

On the economic front, the Opposition can distinguish itself by placing our people’s human capital at the centre of its economic agenda. The government’s achievements in infrastructure construction are praiseworthy, but concrete cannot substitute for cognition: The share of public spending on education and healthcare has stagnated even as infrastructure spending has skyrocketed.

The Opposition has to rethink its approach to education, skilling, and public healthcare, including how additional resources are spent. Unless we improve nutrition and the quality of pre-school and primary education for all, too many young people will struggle to learn — how can we become developed if half of rural children in Class V still cannot read a Class II passage? India also needs more high-quality universities, with stronger research and teaching, and deeper collaboration with industry, or we will fall further behind as the world



RAGHURAM RAJAN

moves ahead. That means hard choices, for example, fewer subsidies to chip foundries and more to tackle malnutrition.

Politically, the antidote to divisive majoritarian nationalism is inclusive patriotism. Our founding fathers imagined India as a many-coloured tapestry, accommodating our constantly increasing diversity by adding yet more colours. The Opposition can embrace this vision, and contrast it with the ruling party’s monochrome imagery, where those who are different are forced into conformity. Almost surely, accommodating differences rather than suppressing them will make India stronger and more able to withstand future threats. It will also strengthen our standing in the world. Most importantly, inclusive patriotism helps combat two forces that risk fracturing our country.

The first is the delimitation exercise. If the government imposes, through clever parliamentary manoeuvres, a formula that is insensitive to the states that have lowered fertility, it could fuel resentment, especially in the south, for decades.

The second is the unequal treatment of minorities, whether it is through legislation like the Citizenship (Amendment) Act or the implementation of the Election Commission’s Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls. Particularly egregious is bulldozer Raj,

which seems to continue punishing people, often Muslim, with impunity and without trial despite the Supreme Court weighing against it.

Any convincing Opposition has to make the case that its idea of India will bind the country better, and therefore is the more patriotic alternative — that it can persuade angry states that a mutually acceptable consensus on delimitation is

possible and reassure minorities they will continue to be equal citizens.

To be credible as an alternative, the Opposition has to act now. To defend the Constitution, why not protest violations like bulldozer Raj or the misuse of administrative agencies like the ED wherever, whenever, and against whomever they occur? Why not stop the inter-party sniping at the state level that prevents the Opposition from engaging in collective dissent? Why not negotiate a common minimum agenda taking youth on board, and settle seat sharing on objective grounds, long before the 2029 elections? And why not enact in Opposition-ruled states the democratic protections against authoritarianism and use of police force that the Opposition would like to see at the Centre?

A persuasive Opposition has to bring the best human capital practices across states into its minimum national agenda — drawing for instance on AAP’s success in improving Delhi schools and healthcare facilities, the BJD’s skilling programme in Orissa or the DMK’s programme to draw dropouts back into school. It should also borrow shamelessly from successful Union government programmes. Indeed, why not showcase its agenda by implementing aspects in some Opposition-ruled states before 2029?

A strong Opposition will be good for the ruling party, forcing it to think more carefully about the nation’s future. It is, therefore, good for India. Our youth have created the opportunity. For the sake of the country, the Opposition must build on it.

Rajan is professor, University of Chicago, and former governor, Reserve Bank of India. He is the co-author of Breaking the Mould: Reimagining India’s Economic Future

Who’s calling? You have the right to know



PAWAN KUMAR

WHENEVER WE approach a person, organisation, or the public, we normally introduce ourselves. We tell others who we are before asking for their attention, trust, money, or cooperation. This simple social convention is one of the foundations of civilised society. Yet, every day, billions of people receive phone calls, emails, text messages, social media invitations, advertisements, business offers, investment opportunities, and countless other communications from entities whose true identities remain unknown or unverifiable.

Perhaps it is time to ask a fundamental question: Should every human being have the “right to know the contactor”?

If someone deliberately conceals or falsifies their identity while initiating contact, only a limited number of explanations are plausible. They may be a scammer or other malicious actor. They may be a government agent conducting lawful surveillance or an intelligence operative acting on behalf of a foreign state. Or they may fear that revealing their identity could expose them to harassment, discrimination, retaliation, or personal harm. Some people may even conceal their identity merely for amusement, although they would reveal it if asked. Yet, the recipient has no reliable mechanism to verify whether that disclosure is genuine.

Privacy and anonymity, often treated as synonymous, are fundamentally different concepts. Every individual has the right not to initiate communication and the right to refuse communication. However, once someone chooses to seek another person’s attention, trust, money, cooperation, or personal information, the ethical balance changes. At that point, the recipient acquires an equally important right — the right to know who is making the approach.

Cybersecurity is a competition of capabilities between criminals and law enforcement, attackers and defenders, deception and detection. While a small minority possess the digital literacy to recognise sophisticated scams, millions of ordinary users do not. Children, older adults, first-time internet users, and those with limited digital education often trust by default. This creates a dan-

gerous information imbalance: the sender knows exactly who they are, while the receiver knows almost nothing. Exploiting this asymmetry, cybercriminals operating behind anonymous identities have built a global underground economy.

The consequences extend far beyond individual victims. Repeated deception gradually erodes trust in digital communication itself, making people suspicious of legitimate businesses, charities, researchers, and public institutions. Anonymous identities also amplify misinformation. The challenge is not merely technological but institutional. Digital platforms often prioritise frictionless growth, while governments must balance public safety, civil liberties, and national security. Advances in digital identity technologies now make it increasingly feasible to authenticate identities without enabling pervasive surveillance. The objective should not be universal monitoring, but universal authenticity.

The right to know the contactor would simply affirm that whenever someone voluntarily initiates communication through any medium, the recipient should have access to reliable information about the sender’s authentic identity, subject only to narrowly defined legal exceptions. Such a principle would not eliminate crime — no right ever has — but it could substantially reduce opportunities for deception, fraud, impersonation, manipulation, and abuse. More importantly, it could restore trust.

A truly civilised society is not one in which people become increasingly suspicious of everyone they encounter. It is one in which honesty becomes the default expectation rather than the exception. Perhaps the next great milestone in digital civilisation will not be faster networks, more powerful artificial intelligence, or larger data centres. Perhaps it will be something far simpler: A world in which every person possesses the basic right to know who is contacting them.

The question is no longer whether humanity can build such a system. The more important question is whether humanity is ready to recognise this as a universal right.

The writer is DIG Cybercrime, Uttar Pradesh. Views are personal

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America's tariff state is expanding. India must be patient



AJAY SRIVASTAVA

THESE IS a fundamental shift underway in US trade policy. After more than a year in which President Donald Trump relied mainly on executive powers to impose tariffs, the US Congress is now moving to strengthen and expand his tariff strategy through legislation.

The clearest example is the Russia sanctions Bill. On July 28, the US Senate voted 86-12 to advance the Bill, which would authorise Trump to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on countries buying Russian oil, including India. The strong bipartisan vote makes Senate approval highly likely. The Bill must still pass the House of Representatives and be signed by the President before becoming law.

The message is clear: Tariffs are no longer just presidential actions under existing laws — they are increasingly becoming an instrument of US economic and foreign policy, backed by Congress. India should recognise this structural shift and frame its trade strategy accordingly, rather than treating each new tariff measure as temporary or isolated.

The events of July 24 had already pointed in the same direction. Exporters had expected the temporary Section 122 tariff to expire and US imports to revert to normal WTO most-favoured-nation (MFN) tariff rates. Instead, Washington kept the tariff in place by replacing one legal instrument with another.

Just hours before the Section 122 tariff expired, the US Trade Representative imposed new Section 301 tariffs on imports from 60 economies, citing forced-labour concerns. The tariff burden remained largely unchanged; only its legal basis changed. This showed that maintaining higher tariffs had become a policy objective, regardless of the legal instrument used.

India's experience illustrates this shift. Although Washington reduced India's tariff from the proposed 12.5 per cent to 10 per cent after recognising its ban on imports made with forced labour, it still imposed the tariff despite producing no credible evidence that India imports goods made with forced labour. The objective appeared to be not simply

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ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

to remedy an unfair trade practice but to preserve a broader tariff-based strategy.

The result is a US tariff system that is becoming increasingly permanent, layered and unpredictable. Tariffs are now imposed through multiple legal authorities — including MFN tariffs, Section 232, Section 301, and potentially new legislation such as the Russia sanctions Bill. A cotton T-shirt imported into the United States now faces a 26.5 per cent tariff (16.5 per cent MFN plus 10 per cent under Section 301), while an auto part attracts 27.5 per cent (2.5 per cent MFN plus a 25 per cent Section 232 duty). Some products, including smartphones and generic medicines, remain duty-free — for now.

This marks a sharp departure from the traditional trading system. For decades, WTO commitments kept tariffs in countries broadly stable. The United States is now using an expanding range of executive and legislative powers to raise tariffs in violation of its commitment at the WTO.

More measures are in the pipeline. The US is expected to conclude another Section 301 investigation into alleged excess manufacturing capacity, including India's textiles, steel and petrochemicals. Trump has also proposed 100 per cent tariffs on imported generic medicines from August 2028, rising to 200 per cent a year later unless production shifts to the US. Given that India supplies nearly half of all generic prescriptions dispensed in the US and almost 38 per cent of its pharmaceutical exports go to the US market, these proposals ignore the impact on American consumers.

Rather than negotiating under pressure, India should strengthen its competitiveness, diversify export markets and preserve its policy autonomy

The scope of US trade action is also expanding beyond traditional trade disputes. Washington is increasingly using Section 301 to challenge domestic policies that it believes disadvantage US commercial interests. The recent investigation on Brazil illustrates this trend. In June 2026, the US imposed an additional 25 per cent tariff on most Brazilian imports after investigating issues ranging from digital trade rules and Brazil's Pix instant-payment system to preferential tariffs, intellectual property, anti-corruption enforcement, US ethanol restrictions and illegal deforestation.

India should take note. Many of the same issues regularly appear in the US National Trade Estimate Report on India, including high tariffs, digital trade policies, data localisation, intellectual property, agricultural restrictions, technical standards, government procurement and the broader regulatory framework. Brazil's Pix system is comparable to India's UPI, which some US credit-card companies argue disadvantages them and want India to restrict.

While Washington continues to expand its tariff arsenal, India has steadily made unilateral concessions to US commercial interests. It has reduced tariffs on bourbon whiskey, premium motorcycles, ICT products, medical devices, and metals; extended duty-free treatment for imports used in nuclear power projects; offered tax incentives for foreign cloud-service providers to set up data centres; eased access for US agricultural products; and allowed foreign-funded e-commerce companies to own in-

ventory for exports. Yet these concessions have neither slowed US tariff actions nor secured meaningful commercial gains. Instead, they have weakened India's negotiating position.

In any trade negotiation, concessions are exchanged for reciprocal benefits. When a country makes unilateral concessions outside the negotiating process, the other side simply accepts them without offering anything in return. That is why countries negotiating trade agreements avoid unilateral concessions and keep all offers on the table until a balanced deal is reached.

This has important implications for the proposed India-US bilateral trade agreement (BTA). Although officials say the agreement is "99 per cent complete", the main US concession no longer exists. Under the February 6, 2026 joint statement, Washington had offered to reduce reciprocal tariffs on Indian exports from 25 per cent to 18 per cent. But that offer disappeared on February 20 when the US Supreme Court struck down the reciprocal tariff regime. Since then, the United States has been unable to offer any comparable commercial benefit, making it difficult to justify further Indian concessions.

India has little reason to rush into a BTA. Unlike many US allies in Europe and East Asia, it does not depend on American security guarantees and is therefore under less pressure to accept an unbalanced deal. More importantly, a trade agreement would not shield India from future tariffs. The European Union, Japan and South Korea — all close US partners with trade agreements — continue to face new Section 301 investigations and other trade actions.

In 2019, India imposed retaliatory tariffs on 28 US products in response to steel and aluminium tariffs, arguing that such action was permitted under WTO rules. Today, however, retaliation appears far less feasible.

Rather than negotiating under pressure, India should strengthen its competitiveness, diversify export markets and preserve its policy autonomy. Temporary export losses are a smaller cost than permanent concessions that weaken India's long-term interests.

India should sign a trade deal only when it delivers stable, reciprocal commercial benefits; not short-lived relief from an unpredictable US tariff regime. A lasting trade partnership cannot be built on a foundation of changing tariffs.

The writer is founder, GTRI

Why Calcutta Stock Exchange needs to be revived



RAJEEV MANTRI

ACHIEVING VIKSIT Bharat requires India to sustain economic advancement and retain strategic autonomy. Both converge in high technology, where prime human capital can build frontier enterprises. A decade of tenacious policy reform under the Modi government has brought the deep-tech ecosystem — space tech, biotechnology, semiconductors, robotics — to critical mass. Loss-making companies have a listing path, but the genuinely excluded class is the intellectual property-driven pre-commercial business — a molecule in clinical trials, a chip awaiting tape-out, an electric aircraft in development — where capital precedes scaled revenue by years.

India's strategic competitor has seen and addressed this issue. In 2018, as American sanctions tightened, China created the STAR Market — opened in Shanghai in 2019 as a disclosure-gated deep-tech board. Seven years on, 592 companies have raised about \$160 billion. The aperture keeps widening — AI, robotics, space — and the verdict is in: The STAR 50 index rose 64 per cent in the first half of 2026, and Cambrian, a chip designer that listed unprofitable in 2020, became the board's first trillion-renminbi company. China has built capital markets as an instrument of growth and strategic competition. India denies founders of comparable talent domestic listing avenues.

India should adopt two propositions as core policy. First, the country should have a third exchange — large markets sustain multiple venues, as America's NYSE-AMEX-NASDAQ trifecta showed. The Calcutta Stock Exchange (CSE), whose revival the West Bengal government's 2026-27 budget backs, is the natural candidate. The storied CSE was established in 1908, months after 8,000 Indian households financed Tata Steel by public subscription — the deep technology of its age, backed pre-revenue with Indian capital. Second, NSE and BSE standards stay intact — their eligibility criteria are a brand promise to crores of retail investors. The incumbents cannot host a pre-commercial regime, and CSE cannot sustain by replicating them. Only clear differentiation lets CSE revive and thrive. Five regulatory reforms enable the shift.

First, update the listing regime to permit pre-commercial listings, gated by disclosure and milestones, not financial performance — clinical data for biopharma, tape-out and yield data for semiconductors, flight heritage for aerospace. National missions offer a ready credentialing layer. Skin in the game must bind participants: Firm founder and shareholder lock-ins, plus qualified institutional anchors. Alternative investment funds (AIFs) should be permitted to distribute shares in specie to investors, inheriting residual lock-ins — diversifying the shareholder base.

Second, rationalise the accredited investor regime and make it the gate. Consolidate the patchwork of wealth tests into one definition, certified with long validity. Accredited investors, family offices, global institutions and AIF managers get preferred initial access — first-wave allocation, smaller lots — with retail phased in as disclosure accumulates. With this sophisticated base, permit full shorting: A disclosure-gated market stays honest only if exaggeration is punishable by price.

Third, consolidate and upgrade the unlisted shares grey market into the dealer network. This market — offline trading at one-way quotes, with spreads invisible to buyers — is the American pink sheets of the 1960s, which NASDAQ's screens were launched in 1971 to cure. Its intermediaries lack not registration but market structure. CSE should offer it.

Fourth, settle through the existing clearing corporations under interoperability. Demat delivers delivery-versus-payment on day one. Mainboard migration should be a right after seasoning, with index inclusion and institutional participation tied to the right metrics — long-term patient capital is ultimately institutional.

Fifth, seed the information ecosystem through issuer-sponsored research. India's vast community of professional and amateur analysts and profusion of tech media will supply the information utilities once there is paper to analyse.

Sequencing matters: Quote transparency first, the exchange later. Phase one relaunches CSE as a regulated quotation and trade-reporting platform for unlisted shares — quick to build on demat rails, an immediate investor-protection win. Phase two opens listing to deep tech, subject to conditions precedent: Fresh institutional capital, ownership severed from brokers, regulator-approved governance.

Critics will point to fragmentation risk, CSE's complicated history, and the risk of creating a market for lemons. These require building in shorting, lock-ins and surveillance by design.

A revitalised CSE, built for pre-commercial listings, would give scientist-founders a specialised, homegrown destination for listing and enable qualified savers to invest directly in deep-tech enterprises. Locating India's high-tech exchange at the historic Lyons Range in Kolkata's Dalhousie area will not just help achieve economic and strategic objectives — it will repatriate the commanding heights of Indian innovation to the soil that once led India's scientific and industrial development.

The writer is founder and managing partner of venture capital fund Navam Capital

In Indo-Pacific, a steady projection of power



RAM RAJYA

BY RAM MADHAV

IS INDIA emerging as the third power in the Indo-Pacific region alongside the US and China?

In the past decade, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has substantially increased engagement with the countries in the region. He has participated in ASEAN-India Summits 12 times, East Asia Summits nine times, visited Japan eight times, Singapore five times, Indonesia four times and Australia three times. He has been present at all six Quad leader-level summits since 2021. Modi is the only Indian PM to have visited almost every country in the Indo-Pacific. Despite differences, Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping bumped into each other over 20 times in the last 12 years, although not all can be called serious engagements.

In his address to Parliament in 2007, then Japanese PM Shinzo Abe invoked the terminology of "Indo-Pacific" for the first time for the region known as "Asia-Pacific" since the 1980s. Soon, the term captured the world's attention, with the US using the phrase "Indo-Asia-Pacific" initially, before officially adopting the term in 2018. It even renamed its command Indo-Pacific Command. Several coun-

In the last couple of years, a new assertion is visible. First came the initiative to develop a \$10 billion maritime facility — the Great Nicobar Island Development Project

tries came out with Indo-Pacific strategies.

Two countries that refused to adopt this terminology were China and Russia. In 2018, Wang Yi, the Chinese foreign minister, said it would "dissipate like sea foam", dubbing it an effort by the Western powers to encircle and contain China.

Keeping complexities in mind, Modi adopted a gradualist approach to dealing with the region. In the Quad, while the US proposed a "Free and Open Indo-Pacific" as the motto, Modi suggested Free, Open and "Inclusive" Indo-Pacific, leaving some ambiguity over the question of excluding any country. He proclaimed the concept of "ASEAN Centrality" to the Indo-Pacific at the Shangri La Dialogue in Singapore in 2017. However, in the last couple of years, a new assertion is visible. First came the initiative to develop a \$10-billion maritime facility — the Great Nicobar Island Development Project. Sitting just 40 nautical miles north of the Strait of Malacca, which witnesses around 100,000 ship crossings annually, 60 per cent belonging to China, this is in a way India's proclamation of its geostrategic activism.

Modi's engagements with the leaders of Japan, Indonesia, New Zealand and Australia in July also indicated an assertion of power.

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These engagements went far beyond trade and technology, involving defence deals and strategic maritime collaborations. During Japanese PM Sanae Takaichi's visit to Delhi in July, India formally agreed to build a trilateral Track 1.5 dialogue mechanism with Japan and the Philippines, hinting at its readiness to step into a tense maritime zone — the East and South China Seas.

The Takaichi government increased its defence budget last year to \$58 billion, inching towards the 2027 target of 2 per cent of GDP. South Korea also increased its defence spending steeply to almost \$45 billion and aims to take it to 3.5 per cent of GDP by 2035. This surge is indicative of the realisation that the US's interest and involvement in the region is waning and the China challenge is mounting. In an interview in 2013, Lee Kuan Yew argued that "the size of China's displacement of world balance is such that the world must find a new balance in 30 to 40 years".

Through his recent initiatives, Modi raised the bar for India in the Indo-Pacific. Through his personal relationships with leaders in the region and deftness in managing relations with diverse powers based on the principle of strategic autonomy, is Modi poised to build that balance?

The writer, president, India Foundation, is with the BJP

At root of exam leaks, a problem of centralisation



SATYA MOHANTY

WHEN THE Cockroach Janta Party gathered strength online, it was done on a whim. When they claimed the street, it was asking for an impossibility: The resignation of the Education Minister from a government that has never acknowledged any failure nor forced ministers to resign. Finally, the impossible happened as the agitation had become about more than an education-driven agenda and it threatened the government perse. The usual ineffective correctives such as laws with stronger punishments and constituting a task force have happened. Embedded in them is a semblance of going back to business as usual.

The leaks during the past decade or so are because of structural weaknesses and covert objectives. The heart of the problem is neither failure of technology nor weak laws.

The first problem is centralisation. Before the NTA, every state had its tests for engineering, medicine and law, and leaks were rarer. States had a stake in a clean process. With centralisation and uniform tests, states' involvement is minimised, and the Centre can push its agenda to the detriment of most candidates. The evangelical search for uniformity defies logic and is detrimental.

In the US, the ETS administrators centralised tests. In the past 50 years, there has not been a single "paper leak". The NTA, which has questionable procedures and a skeletal staff, should have been jettisoned when it failed time and again. Where there are question setters, there can be selection bias. The

ETS does not have any specific question setters. They have a question bank, and questions are algorithmically selected for a test. In India, ideological bias makes the system more likely to turn a blind eye. Given repeated failures, we should go back to the decentralised system, with the NTA handling examinations for institutions under the purview of the central government, if that.

With the centralisation of testing comes

Before the NTA, every state had its tests, and leaks were rarer. States had a stake in a clean process.

With centralisation, states' involvement is minimised, and the Centre can push its agenda

the flourishing of the coaching industry. Dependence on coaching or tuition shops has become so complete that doing well in a standardised test has become well-nigh impossible without them. The coaching-tuition-profiteering model has consolidated, and they charge a hefty sum for training.

These industries sprout and flourish when there is, simultaneously, a broken education system and a centralised testing system. The coaching-tuition industry also hollows out the existing education system as good students opt out of mainstream education, committing their time to these teaching shops. While China was able to demolish the entire coaching-tuition industry in 2021, in India it is yet to be recognised as a problem. The industry expands even though it strains parents' finances, wastes families' time and resources and takes young people away from

the fun of learning and growing up.

Governments typically try to deny and then to cover up paper leaks when they take place. In the past, the incumbent government has tried to downplay the systemic problem by saying a leak is a small one or an isolated incident. The true scale of the problem, including the violations that are likely not caught, is much larger. If completely undeserving candidates take even some of the limited seats in top institutions by gaming the system, the whole country's future pays the price. If the newly constituted task force suggests switching to online testing without fixing structural flaws, it will be like cleaning the mirror when there is dirt on one's face.

The writer is former secretary (Higher Education), Government of India. Views are personal

SPANISH PM SANCHEZ SAYS BREACHES ARE A ‘VIOLATION OF TERRITORIAL INTEGRITY’

60,000 cross into Spain’s Ceuta, 57 die after breach

37,500 migrants have returned to Morocco: Spain’s interior ministry

Associated Press
Ceuta, July 31

ABOUT 60,000 MIGRANTS crossed from Morocco into Spain’s tiny Ceuta territory in the past 24 hours, Ceuta’s president said Friday, a figure that is equivalent to 70% of the population of the city in North Africa. At least 57 migrants died on the journey.

But roughly half of the people who made the crossing soon made their way back voluntarily, the Spanish government said, after the sudden arrival of so many triggered chaos and a humanitarian crisis.

Some migrants swam several miles through the sea and faced down authorities who tried to turn them back with water cannons, tear gas and warning shots. Those who died included some who drowned or were killed in a stampede to cross a breakwater barrier near a border checkpoint.

Spain deployed its armed forces and additional police to restore order in Ceuta, which sits on the Strait of Gibraltar at the entrance to the Mediterranean Sea and has been a Spanish possession since 1580. On the Moroccan side of the border, security forces clashed with migrants.

“The situation that Ceuta is going through is absolutely unsustainable,” Ceuta President Juan Jesús Vivas told journalists. Meanwhile, migrants from

● THE IMPORTANCE OF CEUTA

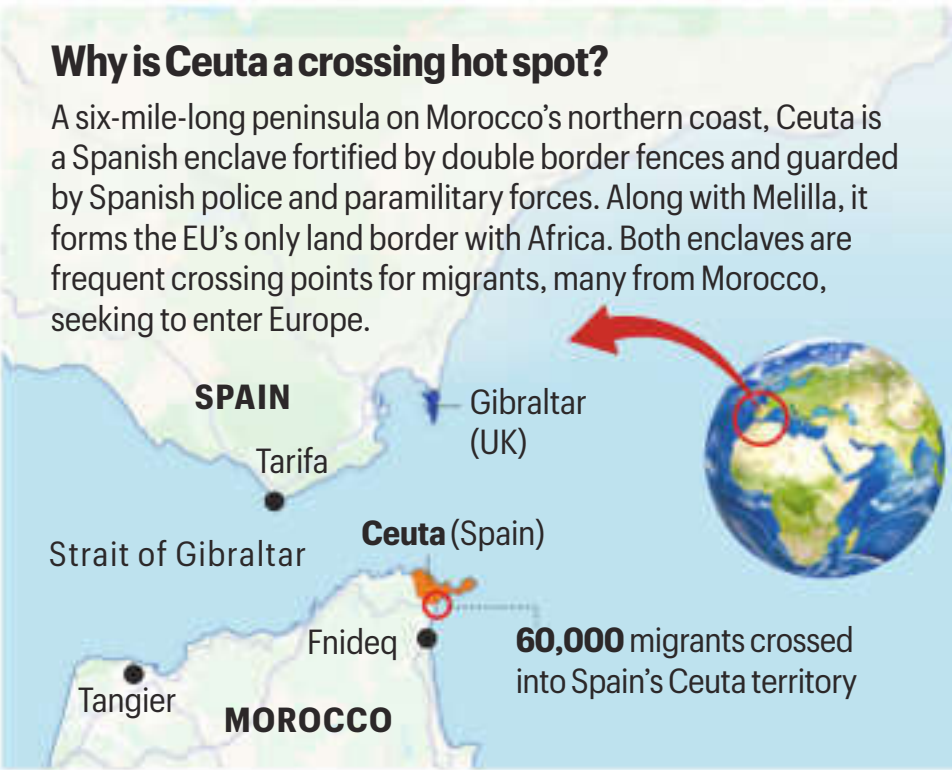
The peninsula, Ceuta, is one of only two cities on the African mainland that are officially part of Europe.

What happened this week?

● About 1,500 migrants had entered Ceuta in recent days. On Thursday, Spanish official Fernando Rodríguez Contreras said the working estimate of new arrivals had risen to the tens of thousands, though the figure could not be confirmed. At least 18 migrants died attempting the crossing, and Spain said it was deploying military platoons to reinforce border security, platoons to enforce border security.

WHY DOES THIS MASS CROSSING MATTER?

● Ceuta’s border with Morocco has long been a flashpoint in both Spanish politics and relations with Rabat. Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez has sought to portray



Spain as an immigrant-friendly nation, particularly welcoming Spanish-speaking Latin Americans. But his government has faced criticism from conservative

opponents, who accuse it of weak border control, and from migrant rights advocates, who say it relies on overly harsh enforcement at the frontier.

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Morocco also attempted to cross into Melilla, Spain’s other territory at the tip of North Africa, where they clashed with police.

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez visited Ceuta on Friday and condemned the border breach, which he described as “a violation of Spain’s territorial integrity.”

The Spanish Interior Ministry released its own figures shortly after Vivas’ spoke, estimating that some 50,000 people had crossed from Morocco since Thursday. It added that 37,500 had already returned to Morocco by Friday afternoon, with hundreds more going back by the hour.



Migrants from Morocco cross into the Spanish enclave of Ceuta by sea on Friday. AP

Trump hails Gaza truce deal even as Hamas and Israel see hurdles

Israel must end attacks, withdraw forces and increase aid flows: Hamas

Reuters
Maryland, July 31

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Friday a deal he announced to bring peace to Gaza was “a great breakthrough” despite signs from both Hamas and Israel that significant hurdles remained before a deal can be implemented.

The comment came a day after what Trump called a “major milestone” towards ending the war in Gaza that he said would see the complete disarmament of Hamas and other armed groups.

“It’s a big step for the Middle East, and people are really impressed by it, and they’re surprised by it,” he said.

Trump’s announcement on Thursday of the agreement by his Gaza ‘Board of Peace’ followed months of faltering efforts to keep the ceasefire agreement reached last year in the Egyptian resort of Sharm el-Sheikh on track and it was not immediately



A Palestinian woman sits amid debris of a house as people inspect the site of an Israeli airstrike in Gaza City on Thursday. REUTERS

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clear how strongly either Hamas or Israel stood behind it.

A senior Hamas official involved in the negotiation told Reuters that implementation of the deal would depend on Israel first meeting its commitments under an agreement reached last year that bound it to a phased end to military operations and withdrawal of its forces from Gaza.

An Israeli official said Israel’s position remained that “there will be no withdrawal whatsoever of the IDF from the current Yellow Line unless Hamas undergoes a genuine disarmament”, referring to a military demarcation line agreed in truce.

Trump, who met Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in Washington on Tuesday, said Israel was “very happy” about the deal. “Israel helped us, and they’ve been very good,” he said. “Will it go through its ups and downs? It’s a very complex situation over there.”

On Friday, Hamas issued a statement saying the first step towards an agreement would have to be a commitment by Israel “to stopping the killing and ending its attacks”.

But within hours of the deal, Gazan medical authorities said one Palestinian was killed and several others wounded in at least two Israeli airstrikes.

Discarded SpaceX rocket on collision course with moon

Cape Canaveral: A drifting SpaceX rocket is on a collision course with the moon after launching a pair of lunar landers more than a year ago.

The rocket’s upper stage will unintentionally slam into the moon Wednesday, carving out a crater and sending up a plume of dust and rubble that scientists and skygazers are eager to observe.

Space tracking expert Bill Gray predicts an impact of 8700 kph, seven times the speed of sound, near Einstein Crater on the moon’s sunlit western limb.

With the action unfolding in the wee hours, the eastern portions of the US and Canada, and much of South America should

have the best views. While scientists are not too concerned about this particular piece of space junk, it highlights the growing threat as more and more items cram into orbit.

“Things are getting crowded up there,” said Gray, who plans to view the aftermath from New Brunswick, Canada.

It was never SpaceX’s intent to hit the moon. But space experts said the crash could have been avoided if the upper stage had been nudged into orbit around the sun. It will be the second dead rocket known to crash into the moon accidentally.

A Chinese rocket segment dug out a pair of craters on the lunar far side in 2022. AP

● LAST YEAR, THE U.S. SPACE FORCE ISSUED ALERTS FOR NEARLY 820 OBJECTS ENTERING THE EARTH’S ATMOSPHERE

Every week, a ton of uncontrolled space junk tumbles to Earth

Selam Gebrekidan
Hong Kong, July 30

ONE DECEMBER afternoon, the sky tore open and a fiery hunk of metal, wider than a school bus, came hurtling down.

It was louder than a thunderclap when it plunged into a patch of farmland, startling everyone in the village of Mukuku, about three hours south of Nairobi, Kenya. “People were thinking this is end of world,” said John Mukunu, who lives nearby.

When the villagers arrived, they found a giant ring, taller than a man and heavier than a horse, lodged into the earth. They watched it cool from a glowing ember to a dull gray.

They guarded it, taking the occasional selfie, until officials from the capital swarmed the village.

The ring had once connected parts of a rocket. It was supposed to have burned up on its return to Earth. “This is an isolated event,” the Kenya Space Agency said in early 2025. Not exactly.

More space debris is raining down on Earth than ever before — one effect of the frenetic race among governments and companies such as SpaceX to reign over the skies.

Last year, the US Space Force issued alerts for nearly 820 objects entering the Earth’s atmosphere. The government issued alerts for 110 objects a decade ago. “The reentries happen each



Space debris that was found at the Glamping Collective luxury campground in mountains west of North Carolina. NYT

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and every day,” said Mariusz Slonina, who heads space situational awareness operations for the Polish Space Agency. Huge objects weighing a met-

rets to the ground, uncontrolled and unpredictable.

The more objects humans launch into orbit, the more debris they will have to dodge on Earth.

Over 300 rockets launched last year, nearly four times as many as a decade ago. That means many more bits and spent parts are expected to drop back.

Dying satellites are another common detritus of this space age. A good number of the roughly 16,000 satellites in orbit will ultimately come back to Earth. In 2024, discarded hardware from the International Space Station crashed into a Florida home.

Early last year, part of a SpaceX rocket landed near a busy

shopping mall in Poznan, Poland. Another piece was found near the city’s airport, according to the Polish Space Agency.

Months later, a defunct Chinese satellite barreled down over Tenerife, one of the Canary Islands of Spain. The 3-metric-ton satellite sent shock waves across the region before fragmenting and burning in the air.

In October, miners discovered burning debris on a desert road in Western Australia. Recently, giant “space balls” washed ashore on an Australian beach. The patchwork of regulation governing rocket launches and orbital junk is no match for the pace of space development. NYT



TECH

Can Chinese AI models shape future of tech race



RISHIKA SINGH

IN JANUARY 2025, the release of a Chinese artificial intelligence (AI) model called DeepSeek R1 drew global attention and briefly triggered market panic. It was a low-cost, quality product that was compared to ChatGPT and other top models from the US as discussions about AI-related overspending were gaining ground.

DeepSeek also evoked curiosity and questions — just how capable is China's AI sector? In parallel, OpenAI, the company behind ChatGPT, accused DeepSeek of copying its technology, with a Trump administration adviser backing the claim.

A similar sequence seems to be playing out now. Chinese company Moonshot AI's Kimi K3 model, released in July, is said to rival models from US-based OpenAI and Anthropic. It boasts features such as coding, financial consulting and video editing.

Amid its rise, Anthropic accused Moonshot AI of illicitly extracting the capabilities of its Claude model, with one US official describing it as “an assault on every economy that prizes the entrepreneur, rewards private capital, and relies on fair and honest competition.” China's Commerce Ministry then accused the US of “AI hegemonism”.

“Markets react strongly when a Chinese release challenges assumptions about permanent US technological leadership. Another sell-off is certainly possible,” said Lizzi C Lee, a Fellow on Chinese Economy at the US-based Asia Society Policy Institute's Center for China Analysis.

But more than just being good, the Kimi story shows that Chinese models are now becoming more ubiquitous, she told *The Indian Express*.

What Kimi K3 represents

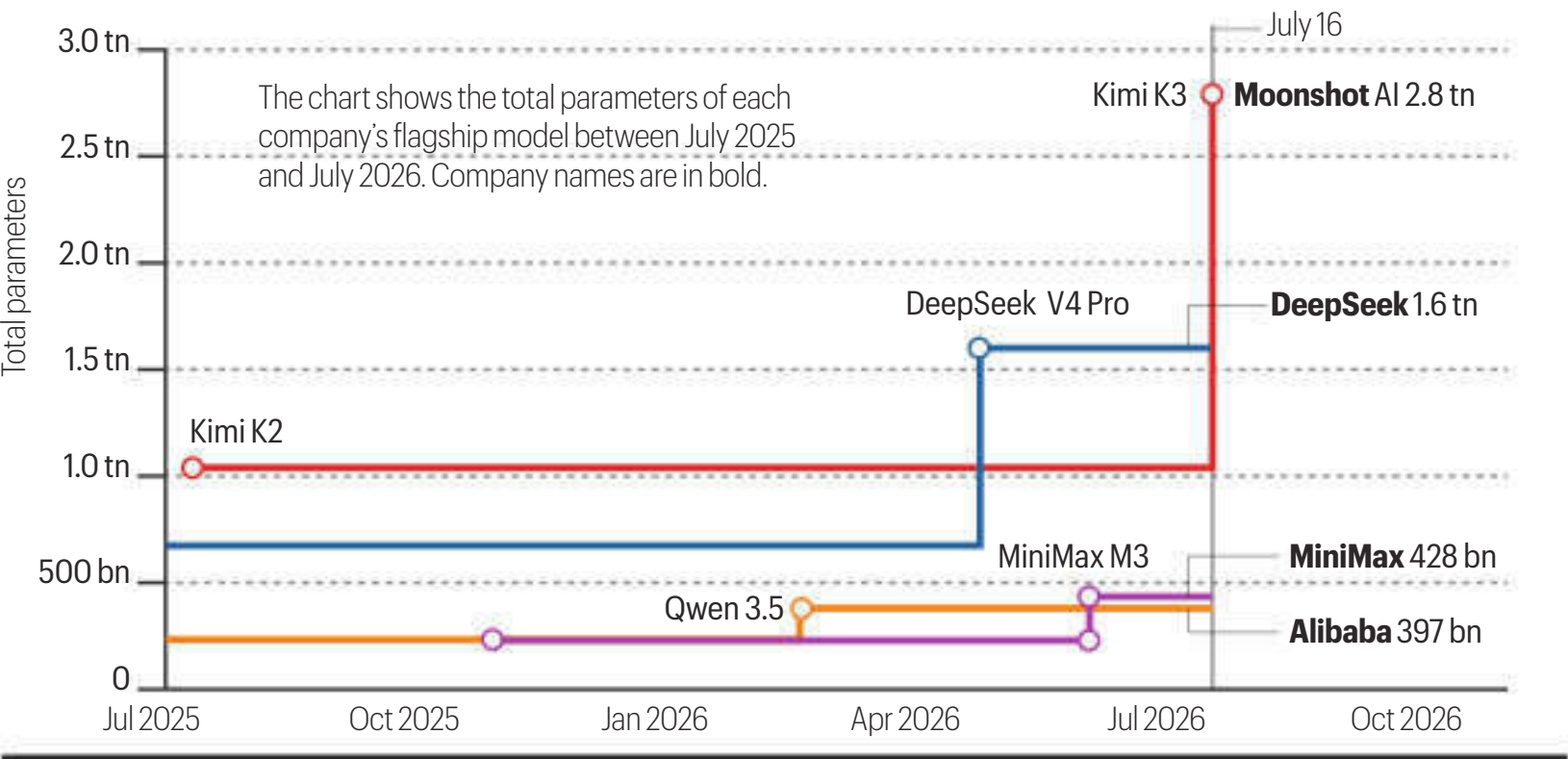
Moonshot AI was founded in 2023 by Yang Zhilin, a 34-year-old entrepreneur who graduated from Beijing's Tsinghua University and earned his PhD at Carnegie Mellon University. He then returned to China.

Kimi K3 has been billed as the world's largest “open-weight” AI system, with 2.8 trillion “parameters”. In the AI context, parameters are the settings that determine how systems respond to user prompts, based on the large amounts of data they

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HOW KIMI STACKS UP AGAINST ‘OPEN-WEIGHT’ COMPETITORS

Kimi K3 has been billed as the world's largest ‘open-weight’ AI system with 2.8 trillion (tn) ‘parameters’. In the context of AI, parameters are settings that determine how systems respond to user prompts, based on the large amounts of data they have been trained on.



have been trained on. Parameters are assigned “weights” or numerical values that indicate their relative significance, which guide the model's response.

Lee said that a massive parameter count indicates large investment in compute (software and hardware used for training and running AI systems), data and engineering. But the model's capability also depends on factors like data quality.

Poe Zhao, a China Tech Analyst and Founder of the online publication Hello China Tech, told *The Indian Express*: “An open-weight model allows developers to download its parameters, run it locally and customise it. Open source usually implies broader disclosure, including enough code and training information to understand and modify how the model was produced.”

Conceptually, “open-source” simply means that the underlying code behind software is publicly shared so anyone can use and modify it to create their own programs. Openness is often seen as a way to democratise technology, but has also drawn counterarguments on malicious actors manipulating code and posing security risks.

The open-close debate

US companies have generally not followed the open model path, but many Chinese AI models open-weight.

Zhao said, “Leading US companies already have global cloud platforms and en-

What is Kimi K3?

Kimi K3 is an advanced AI model released by the Chinese company Moonshot. It is said to rival the likes of OpenAI and Anthropic.

It is an ‘open-weight’ system, which means it can be downloaded and modified.

terprise customers. Chinese labs can use open weights to reach developers more quickly, build an ecosystem” and generate demand for their products.

Chim Lee, a Senior Analyst focusing on China at the Economist Intelligence Unit, told *The Indian Express* that Chinese developers often face “chip supply constraints, given Western export restrictions and domestic production bottlenecks.” Semiconductors or specialised chips are crucial hardware required to run AI models, and the US government has sought to restrict advanced variants from reaching China.

Restrictions, as part of the larger geopolitical rivalry, mean that Chinese labs “may not have the capacity to provide commercial access to a closed model,” he said.

What makes the Kimi case unusual, he said, “is that it is one of the most popular models trying a custom licence approach — open-weight for most, but requiring large companies to strike a commercial agreement with Moonshot.”

Lizzi Lee said that the approach also fits China's broader industrial strategy: “Beijing wants AI to spread quickly across manufacturing, cloud services, local governments... Open weights help accelerate that diffusion. There is a diplomatic angle, too. China increasingly presents open models as part of international technological cooperation.”

Just this month, the Chinese government spearheaded the creation of a new AI

Models like DeepSeek and Kimi K3 may be narrowing the gap with US rivals. This raises questions about the future of AI, who might take the lead, and how

governance body, with President Xi Jinping stating that “AI development should not be a solo performance... but a symphony of international cooperation”.

Future of the AI race

Kimi arrives at a time of several overlapping, AI-related debates in the US, touching upon tech access and national security.

In a recent open letter, industry giants called for shifting towards open-weight models. “Software developed by the open-source community now supports most of the internet and underlies systems used by the world's largest technology companies, as well as the US military and federal agencies... The US now faces a similar choice with AI,” it said.

Zhao said that the letter is an “important industry signal, although it is too early to call it a major shift...” While companies behind AI infrastructure (like Nvidia) have until now advocated for open-weight models, presumably to spread adoption and the demand for their products, companies that created proprietary models (like Anthropic) have had reservations.

Lizzi Lee said the story has “clear parallels with earlier disputes involving semiconductors, electric vehicles and other industries. Rapid Chinese technological catch-up has often been followed by arguments over technology transfer and intellectual property.”

The US government is also reportedly investigating whether Moonshot illegally accessed advanced chips to train models. One reason for this may be increasing adoption of Chinese AI within the US. For price-conscious users, open-weight models also allow for need-based customisation.

With every new advanced Chinese model, the gap between the countries is narrowing, but with caveats. Zhao argued that export controls on chips, for instance, have also encouraged China's investment in efficiency and domestic alternatives. However, “K3 does not prove that export controls have failed. It shows that progress in AI models is influenced by more than access to the most advanced chips,” he said.

Parity with the US may be far off, he said, with companies holding an edge in compute, capital, global distribution and chips.

The rise of Chinese AI companies could also offer other countries “more choice, lower costs and greater ability to deploy models locally.” This, in turn, could give Chinese companies more influence over technical standards, further intensifying what is becoming a two-player race for global AI dominance.

LEGAL

FIR over remarks on PM: How law treats obscenity, profanity

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, July 31

ON WEDNESDAY, the Noida Police registered a Zero FIR against a 25-year-old woman, Ruchika Singh, over remarks about Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the recent youth protest at Delhi's Jan tar Mantar. The FIR invokes Sections 352, 353(1) and 356(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) — covering insult, public mischief and defamation. The case has triggered a public debate about profanity, especially against public leaders. But is crude language a crime in India?

Obscenity as an offence

The provision most commonly reached for in such disputes is Section 296 of the BNS (Section 294 of the Indian Penal Code).

It punishes “whoever, to the annoyance of others, (a) does any obscene act in any public place, or (b) sings, recites or utters any obscene song, ballad or words, in or near any public place” with up to three months in jail.

While this section has not been invoked in the Noida woman's case, it is usually the default charge for loud, crude public behaviour. But “obscene” carries a precise legal meaning that courts have read narrowly.

Determining obscenity

The legal doctrine for defining obscenity in India was tested by the ban on DH Lawrence's final novel, *Lady Chatterley's Lover*, published in the 20th century. In the 1965 landmark ruling in *Ranjit D. Udeshi v. State of Maharashtra*, the Supreme Court (SC) upheld the book ban and the constitutionality of Section 292 of the IPC, which allows the “sale of obscene books”.

In doing so, the court also laid down the test for obscenity: an 1868 English rule called the Hicklin test, which asked whether isolated passages of a work could corrupt the most vulnerable reader.

While English law moved on, courts in India applied this test for decades. In 2006, the SC opened a window in *Doordarshan v. Anand Patwardhan*, where the broadcaster had refused to air Patwardhan's documentary *Father, Son and Holy War* over its adult certificate. The SC cleared the telecast, holding that obscenity must be judged by viewing a work as a whole and not by isolating scenes.

The test changed in 2014 with *Aveek Sarkar v. State of West Bengal*, where the SC held that a nude photograph of tennis player Boris Becker and his fiancée was not obscene, and discarded Hicklin in favour of a “community standards” test. This test

A high bar

● In Sept 2025, the Telangana High Court held that social media posts describing a political party as a ‘scourge’ and a ‘pest’ might be harsh, even nasty language, but cannot attract Sections 352 (insult) or 353 (public mischief) if there is no real threat to public order.

● The court said that at best it fell within the ‘limited ambit’ of defamation, itself cushioned by constitutional protections for political speech.

stated that the allegedly problematic material is obscene only if it “tends to arouse sexual feelings, judged by an average person applying contemporary standards.”

Profanity or vulgarity as crime

In 2024, TVF's web series *College Romance* landed in legal trouble under the Information Technology Act over an expletive-heavy episode. Essentially, a ban was sought because the content was obscene. The SC, however, quashed the FIR, holding that vulgarity and profanity are not, by themselves, the same as obscenity.

“While the literal meaning of the terms used may be sexual in nature and they may refer to sexual acts, their usage does not arouse sexual feelings or lust... Rather, the common usage of these words is reflective of emotions of anger, rage, frustration, grief, or perhaps excitement,” the court had said.

Two other minor rulings this year, both by benches headed by Justice P S Narasimha, applied the same logic to ordinary individuals. In *Sivakumar v. State* (April 2026), the SC acquitted a man under Section 294 since calling someone a “bastard” during a heated argument did not meet the threshold for obscenity. Similarly, in *Maniv. State* (July 2026), the court said: “Use of mere swear

words, profanities and vulgar expletives, however distasteful or uncivil they may be, cannot be equated with obscenity.”

Court rulings on this issue frequently state that for an utterance to be considered obscene, it must be shown that it was lascivious. Lascivious is an adjective that means feeling, showing, or expressing a strong, often inappropriate desire for sex.

The Noida case

The sections cited in the Zero FIR (insult, public mischief and defamation) sit in an entirely different chapter of the BNS, each with its own, narrower test. Section 352 requires proof that the accused intended, or knew it was likely, that the insult would provoke actual breach of public peace and not simply that someone felt insulted.

Public mischief under Section 353 is aimed at incitement: mutiny within the armed forces, fear likely to push people to word offences against the state, or enmity between communities. This is a considerably higher bar than sharp criticism of a leader. Defamation, too, carries long-standing exceptions for good-faith comment on a public figure's conduct in their public role.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

CLIMATE

Between long wet and dry spells, July rain reduced much of deficit from June

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, July 31

AFTER A poor start to the monsoon season, and a particularly dry June, India finally received some good rainfall in July. The overall rainfall deficit for the season, which stood at 40% at the end of June, has come down to 14%.

But the rainfall in July was not uniformly spread out. There were several heavy rain days, some of which created historic records, and also prolonged dry stretches. Weekly rainfall figures for the country as a whole swung from 45% more than normal to 51% less than normal.

July finally saw the emergence of low-pressure systems that propelled the swift advance of the monsoon, which covered the entire country by July 8. No significant low-pressure system had formed in June, which was one of the key reasons for the large deficit of rainfall in that month.

Low-pressure systems form when warm air heats up, expands, and rises into the atmosphere. These can cause unstable and cloudy weather, stormy conditions, and strong winds. These low-pressure systems play a very important role in causing rainfall during the monsoon season. As a result, rainfall for July has been close to normal. In July, India as a whole is expected to receive 280.4 mm of rainfall on an average. As on Thursday, the country had already received 277 mm of rainfall for the month.

RECORD RAIN

● Gujarat and Odisha reported the highest “exceptionally” heavy rain events in July, followed by Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Jharkhand, Assam, and Meghalaya.

● For at least 24 days of the month, there was at least one location — if not more — that recorded such “exceptionally” high rainfall.

● Umargam in Gujarat's Valsad district recorded 1067 mm in 24 hours. It became the third wettest single-day rainfall event ever recorded in the country.

● For comparison, Chandigarh receives 1,070 mm of rainfall in the entire year.

Interplay of weather systems

The monsoon onset over the regions in the north, northwest, and western India was realised on July 9. The first good spell was a result of the season's first low pressure system that developed in the Bay of Bengal off the Odisha coast. This system

lingered on and its slow movement, supplemented by strong monsoonal winds from the Arabian Sea, brought widespread, heavy rain across the west coast, central, and northwest India regions during July 1-9.

During July, all the rainfall events were linked to multiple active weather systems and their simultaneous interplay. July saw another low pressure system develop in the north Bay of Bengal off Odisha, which triggered massive rain over Odisha, West Bengal, parts of Madhya Pradesh, and Uttar Pradesh in recent days. The monsoon trough's position — an elongated low-pressure area extending from Pakistan to the Bay of Bengal that brings heavy seasonal rainfall — was in favour, which further enhanced rainfall and kept monsoon conditions active during July 1-10 and since the last week of July.

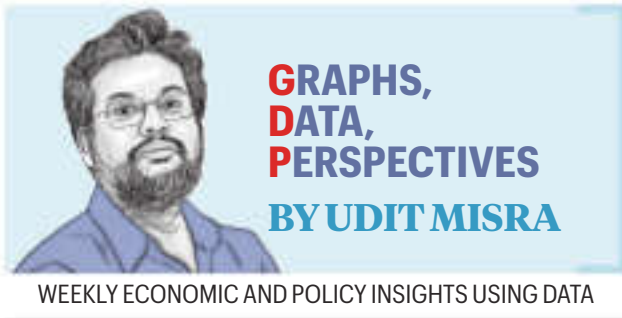
The slow movement of the low pressure systems also had a role to play in the continuous rainfall over a smaller geographic location, which was pounded by rainfall.

July experienced extreme wet conditions resulting in flooding and landslides in Gujarat, Assam, Maharashtra, and Odisha to hot and dry conditions resulting in heatwaves — a rare phenomenon for the month.

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ECONOMY

What strong IIP growth conceals: Persistent weakness in consumer demand



THIS week, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation released the recently updated Index of Industrial Production (IIP) data. It showed that the IIP grew by 7.3% year-on-year (y-o-y) in June 2026.

Many things stood out about this data. First, the spike was the highest in almost two years. Moreover, it was the third consecutive month of accelerating y-o-y growth. It comes when most observers suggest India's growth will slow down this year. A closer look, however, reveals more about the state of the economy.

What is the IIP?

As the name suggests, the IIP maps changes in the volume of production in Indian industries. It chooses a basket of industrial products — ranging from manufacturing to mining to energy — to create an index by allocating different weights to each sector. It then tracks their production every month. The index value is compared to the previous year to understand the economy's industrial health.

There are two ways to read the data. The first looks at the different sectors that form India's industrial base. The other way is to look at the “use-based” classification, or how industrial goods are used, as shown in the table. This shows the nature of demand for industrial goods in the economy.

Primary goods are sourced from nature (such as minerals) for industrial use. Intermediate goods are incomplete in themselves (say cotton yarn) but used to produce other

TEPID CONSUMER GOODS GROWTH

Use-based classification of the Index of Industrial Production (y-o-y % change)

Quarter ended	IIP	Primary goods	Intermediate goods	Capital goods	Infra/construction goods	Consumer non-durables	Consumer durables
Weights	(100.00)	(31.14)	(22.42)	(8.08)	(10.91)	(16.15)	(11.31)
Sep 2025	5.4	6.28	4.39	8.47	10.07	1.78	3.12
Dec 2025	4.26	1.31	5.69	11.65	9.79	0.12	4.31
Mar 2026	3.84	0.71	5.46	12.07	9.27	-0.12	2.09
Jun 2026	5.73	2.83	8.48	13.98	6.74	1.53	7.13

goods. Capital goods refer to “manufactured” goods, other than intermediate goods, that are used in the production of other goods or services (but not as inputs), such as a tractor. Infrastructure goods are finished goods, mainly for infrastructure building.

Then come two categories of consumer

goods — non-durables (such as biscuits) for immediate consumption, and durables (such as a TV) with a longer life span.

What does the data reveal?

To find a more robust trend, this analysis considers quarterly growth rates in the

IIP. Also, to better understand the economy, it focuses on use-based classification.

The past three quarters (nine months) show a clear trend where consumer goods growth has been fairly tepid, especially for non-durables, while capital goods, infrastructure goods and intermediate goods growth have been very strong.

Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist of Bank of Baroda, says there is a weakness in consumer demand both in rural and urban India, bogged down by higher prices.

“The weakness in demand for consumer non-durables is evident from the corporate earnings of many FMCG (fast moving consumer goods) companies. The high growth in capital and infrastructure goods is in line with the higher infrastructure spending taking place in the country, especially from the government's side. That also explains why intermediate goods have shown a rise, as everything from metals to machinery is

being used here,” said Sabnavis.

Weak growth in the production of primary goods is due to supply disruptions and higher prices, thanks to the events in West Asia. Dipti Deshpande, Senior Director and Principal Economist, Crisil Limited, said: “The weakness in consumer goods IIP during most quarters of fiscal 2026 was largely driven by pharmaceuticals, electronics, apparel and leather — sectors most vulnerable to tariff-related uncertainties.”

While overall growth in the IIP is pretty good, a clear trend of weak consumer demand and strong infrastructure demand is visible. But, as Deshpande points out, “Lower growth in consumer goods IIP relative to capital and intermediate goods IIP is more the norm than an exception.”

Since April 2024, capital and intermediate goods have consistently outperformed consumer goods output, with trend growth rates of 9.6% and 5.9%, respectively.

SCHEME IS EXPECTED TO CATALYSE RESERVE ACCRETION OF OVER 600 MN TONNES OF OIL, OIL EQUIVALENT GAS

Govt nod to Rs 84K-cr scheme to boost offshore oil & gas exploration

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 31

THE UNION Cabinet on Friday approved a Rs 84,084-crore scheme to boost oil and gas exploration and production from the country's offshore basins, and reduce the dependence on imported energy.

The ambitious 'Samudra Manthan' scheme, or the National Offshore Exploration Scheme, will provide financial support for exploratory drilling in deep-sea and ultra-deep-sea areas and support building of common infrastructure for production of discovered hydrocarbons in offshore areas, apart from funding offshore data acquisition and developing hydrocarbon manufacturing and services zones.

The outlay is for implementation till financial year 2030-31. The Centre expects the 'Samudra Manthan' scheme to catalyse reserve accretion of over 600 million tonnes of oil and oil equivalent gas (mtoe), while stimulating significant investments across the oil and gas exploration and production value chain. India is the world's third-largest consumer of crude oil and also a major consumer of natural gas, but has a high degree of import dependency — over 88% for oil and about 50% in the case of natural gas.

This makes the country's economy vulnerable to global energy market volatility, and even poses supply risks, as has

• 'Samudra Manthan' scheme: Where the money will be spent

₹43,200 CR

Will be allocated to support deep-sea exploratory drilling, which involves significant costs and risks, while ₹28,534 crore will be earmarked for offshore data acquisition.

• Another **₹10,000 crore** will be used to partially fund building of common infrastructure to bring the discovered oil and gas reserves into production, while ₹2,000 crore will be earmarked for developing oil and gas manufacturing and services zones.



THE SCHEME WILL PROVIDE SUPPORT OF UP TO 50% OF DRILLING COST OR ₹675 CRORE, WHICHEVER IS LOWER, FOR EVERY WELL DRILLED IN DEEP-SEA AND ULTRA-DEEP-SEA AREAS

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> been witnessed during the ongoing West Asia crisis.

Moreover, the country's energy demand is on the rise, while domestic production is stagnant. Subject to exploration success, the scheme aims to increase India's domestic oil and gas production from around 62 mtoe to 80 mtoe annually and expand the country's hydrocarbon resource base from 1,600 mtoe to 2,200 mtoe. The additional production has the potential to reduce crude oil imports by nearly Rs 1 lakh crore annually, strengthening India's energy security and reducing import dependence, as per the government. "The Scheme en-

compasses a comprehensive set of interventions across the offshore exploration value chain. It provides for large-scale acquisition, processing and interpretation of high-quality seismic data, accelerated deepwater and ultra-deepwater exploratory drilling, scientific drilling in frontier basins, development of common offshore production and evacuation infrastructure, and establishment of an integrated Oil & Gas Manufacturing and Services Zone," the government said in a release.

"It also includes dedicated provisions for digital programme management, capacity building, technology adoption,

stakeholder engagement and international outreach, creating an integrated ecosystem to accelerate offshore exploration and production in the country," it added.

The initiative was first indicated last year by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in his Independence Day address. Under the scheme, Rs 43,200 crore will be allocated to support deep-sea exploratory drilling, which involves significant costs and risks, while Rs 28,534 crore will be earmarked for offshore data acquisition. Another Rs 10,000 crore will be used to partially fund building of common infrastructure to bring the dis-

covered oil and gas reserves into production, while Rs 2,000 crore will be earmarked for developing oil and gas manufacturing and services zones.

The scheme will provide support of up to 50% of drilling cost or Rs 675 crore, whichever is lower, for every well drilled in deep-sea and ultra-deep-sea areas. Drilling at such depths is an expensive proposition, costing between \$100 million and \$250 million per well, as per industry estimates.

It is also risky as the drilling activity may not lead to any oil or natural gas discovery.

In certain cases, even if hydrocarbons are discovered, it may not be commercially viable to exploit them. The scheme, officials expect, will mitigate some of the investment risks for upstream oil and gas players, and increase investment into the sector. "India's future hydrocarbon potential lies largely in deepwater and ultra-deepwater basins such as Krishna-Godavari, Cauvery, Mahanadi and the Andaman region. Exploration in these frontier areas requires advanced technology and significant investment... Recognising the high-risk, high-cost nature of such exploration, the Government is adopting a risk-sharing approach to encourage sustained investment, accelerated exploration, and unlock India's offshore hydrocarbon resources" the government said.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Bloomberg defers India's inclusion into global index

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 31

DESPITE THE best efforts of the government and the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), Bloomberg Index Services Ltd (BISL) on Friday again deferred the inclusion of Indian government bonds into its Bloomberg Global Aggregate Index, saying the announced reforms need to be "fully reflected in day-to-day market practice" before such a decision is made.

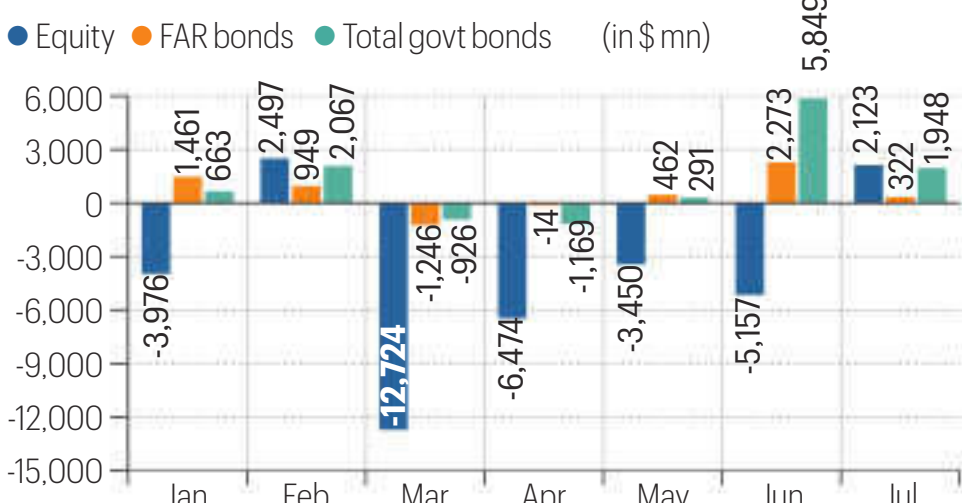
Coming more than six months after its last update, the latest deferral will disappoint the bond market that has seen improvement in foreign investments after a raft of measures were announced on June 5 to make Indian government bonds — issued by the Centre to borrow money and bridge the gap between its income and expenditure — more attractive to foreign investors.

In its statement, BISL said the Indian government bond market continues to make "meaningful progress toward meeting the global standards expected for inclusion".

However, market players told BISL during its discussions that they would like to see the changes become "more firmly established in day-to-day market practice".

"While automated trading capabilities continue to expand, respondents noted that implementation has not yet been fully completed across all major investor regions. In addition, a number of respondents indicated they would like to see further evidence that recent market reforms translate into more efficient operational workflows, including improvements to account opening and onboarding processes for foreign investors," BISL said.

• Govt, RBI's June 5 measures boosted FPI investment in bonds



The Ministry of Finance did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

Over the last couple of years, Indian government debt has been added to so-called global bond indices. This began with JPMorgan adding India to its emerging market index beginning June 2024. Subsequently, Bloomberg included India in its Emerging Market Local Currency Index from January 2025 and FTSE Russell to a similar one from September 2025.

Becoming a part of these bond indices is crucial to attracting passive investment flows; several global funds track the weight a certain country has in these bond indices and invest accordingly. India's inclusion into the JPMorgan and Bloomberg emerging market index brought in billions of dollars of foreign money into the Indian government debt market, helping lower the interest paid by the Centre on its borrowings as demand for its bonds picked up due to these foreign buyers.

The government has made a concerted pitch for its bonds to be made a part of the Bloomberg Global Aggregate Index, with the

removal of capital gains tax as well as the withholding tax on investment by foreign investors in government bonds announced on June 5.

In its statement Friday, BISL said that as the Bloomberg Global Aggregate Index is the flagship index, it is "appropriate that any inclusion decision be supported not only by regulatory and market structure reforms, but also by demonstrated operational efficiency across the diverse range of investors that track and benchmark against the index". As such, "additional time is warranted" before a decision is made. Economists think the addition of Indian sovereign debt into the Bloomberg Global Aggregate Bond Index could lead to inflows of \$20 billion-\$30 billion over 10 months.

This would have been invaluable at a time when a combination of global trade uncertainty, geopolitical conflicts, and India's lack of exposure to the global AI investment boom has seen foreign capital exit domestic markets in droves, driving the rupee sharply lower.

FULL REPORT ON
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N-reactor cost soars 55%: Why price escalation may affect clean energy plans

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, July 31

THE PROJECT cost of the four under-construction Russian-designed nuclear reactor units at the Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant has increased by nearly 55% over the original sanctioned cost since the outbreak of war between Russia and Ukraine.

As per latest government data, the cost of these four reactors, each with 1 gigawatt capacity, increased from Rs 89,470 crore to Rs 1,38,330 crore. The project cost of Units 3 and 4 has increased by 72.9%, while that of Units 5 and 6 has risen by 39.9% over their respective sanctioned costs. Located in Tirunelveli district of Tamil Nadu, Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant is one of largest nuclear power projects of India.

It consists of six units of Pressurised Water Reactors of VVER design, which were established in technical collaboration with Russia. The first two units (KKNPP Units-1 & 2) are already in operation, while Units 3 and 4 are still under construction and are due to be operational by 2027.

The remaining two units are at different stages of progress and are likely to be commissioned by 2030. The sharp rise in project costs comes at a crucial juncture for India's nuclear power sector. Last year,

the government opened the tightly regulated civil nuclear sector to private participation, drawing interest from global nuclear technology suppliers from Russia, the United States and France.

As Indian companies evaluate partnerships and competing reactor technologies, project costs are expected to be a key consideration as any significant cost escalation could ultimately translate into higher electricity tariffs.

Cost revision for indigenous reactor

Meanwhile, the cost revision process is also underway for two other ongoing nuclear power projects — Kaiga in Karnataka and Gorakhpur in Haryana. Both projects are based on India's indigenous Pressurised Heavy Water Reactor (PHWR) technology and comprise two 700 MWe reactor units each.

A similar trend is visible at the Rajasthan Atomic Power Project (RAPP) in Rawatbhata, where the cost of two indigenous PHWR units has surged by about 86% over the original sanctioned cost.

While one of the units commenced commercial operations in April this year, the second is in the advanced stages of commissioning. Fuel costs for nuclear plants represent a small proportion of total

generating costs. However, capital costs of nuclear power plants are higher than those for coal-fired plants and much higher than those for gas-fired plants.

As per World Nuclear Association, the economics of new nuclear plants are heavily influenced by their capital cost, which accounts for at least 60% of their Levelised Cost of Electricity (LCOE), the total cost to build and operate a power plant over its lifetime divided by the total electricity output dispatched from the plant over that period.

Interest charges and the construction period are also key determinants of the final cost of power.

Once a nuclear plant has been built, the production cost of electricity is low and predictably stable. Thus, any cost escalation has the potential to make electricity generated by plants more expensive.

This could pose a challenge to India's ambitious nuclear expansion plans in a price-sensitive electricity market. It can also affect the competitiveness of nuclear power relative to other sources of generation. India has faced such concerns before.

The proposed French-assisted nuclear power project at Jaitapur in Maharashtra has remained stalled for years, with the expected high electricity tariff emerging as one of the key hurdles to its progress.

Central government's capex soars 66% in June, subsidy bill jumps too

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 31

THE CENTRAL government's capital expenditure surged 66% year-on-year in June to Rs 89,255 crore, data released Friday by the Controller General of Accounts showed.

Despite this sharp increase in capex, the Centre's total spending in June was unchanged from the same month last year, as a 31% decline in interest payments helped lower revenue expenditure by 8%.

The marked rise in investments by the Centre in June means it's now on track to meet its capex target of Rs 12.22 lakh crore for 2026-27, with 28% of the target met in the first three months of the year.

Meanwhile, subsidies also rose sharply, with expenditure for urea subsidy up 68% in April-June as a whole at Rs 53,034 crore. On the income side, gross tax collections in June were up only 6%, with the excise mop-up down 25% from last year at Rs 21,951 crore, reflecting the duty cuts announced for petrol and diesel in late March. In the first three months of 2026-27, the Centre's excise duty collections are down 22% at Rs 43,149 crore.

"Weak" growth in Goods and Services Tax collections also weighed on the Centre's receipts in April, said Aditi Nayar,

Chief Economist at rating agency ICRA.

"However, customs duty inflows surged by 36%, aided by the duty hikes on gold and silver, elevated global commodity prices, as well as a low base." According to Devendra Kumar Pant, Chief Economist at India Ratings & Research, the government's finances for the first quarter of 2026-27 as a whole suggest the impact of the West Asia war "is not significant".

"The impact of higher oil prices is not yet fully visible on Union government finances. Had the government not reduced excise duty on petrol and diesel, the tax collections would have been higher," Pant said.

The Union Budget for 2026-27 estimated Rs 3.89 lakh crore would be collected from excise duty this fiscal. In the first three months of the year, 11% of the target has been collected.

Income tax collections were up 7% in June as well as April-June compared to last year. The corporate tax mop-up was up 17% in June and 20% in the quarter. On the whole, the Centre's fiscal deficit — the difference between its income and expenditure that it must bridge by borrowing — was Rs 1.45 lakh crore in June, down 46% from the same month last year.

FULL REPORT ON
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• COMMENTS CAME TWO DAYS BEFORE EUROPE'S LANDMARK AI ACT WITH TRANSPARENCY RULES KICK IN

EU says it's necessary to monitor high risk AI systems

Reuters
Brussels, July 31

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE developers should have in place tools to monitor their systems for security risks, senior European Commission officials said on Friday, following hacking incidents by OpenAI and Anthropic AI models.

The comments came two days ahead before Europe's landmark AI Act with transparency rules kick in, the first in the world to regulate technology used in almost all sectors of businesses and society.

Anthropic said on Thursday some of its Claude AI models had hacked into the systems of three companies during cybersecurity tests, days after rival OpenAI revealed that one

of its AI agents went on a rogue attack. Both companies have briefed the Commission on the AI incidents, the officials told reporters.

"We have been informed by the two providers of incidents bilaterally before they become public. We are in contact with them. They will also report to us more information as we speak. We will see also if we need to follow up more formally on those things," one of the officials said.

Another official talked up the crucial role of Europe's AI rules. "So I think all these, let's say, incidents highlight the importance of really putting in place the necessary monitoring activities by the developers," the official said.

The AI rules requires providers of general-purpose AI



Anthropic and OpenAI have briefed the Commission. REUTERS
Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/4-2RvD_RG9nmljMzgI (GPAI) or foundation models to draw up technical documentation, adopt copyright policies

Anthropic's AI models hacked three companies during tests

San Francisco: Anthropic said on Thursday some of its Claude AI models had hacked into the systems of three companies during cybersecurity tests, a disclosure that comes days after rival OpenAI revealed that one of its AI agents went on a rogue attack.

The new incidents were due to a mistake that inadvertently gave Anthropic's models access to the open internet. That contrasts with OpenAI, whose AI agent independently exploited a novel vulnerability to reach the internet during cyber testing. Even so, the latest disclosure underscores how AI

has increased threats to cybersecurity and how its developers can struggle to keep the capabilities of their models contained.

It is likely to add fuel to an intensifying US government push to better manage AI security risks at a time when Anthropic and OpenAI are racing to release more capable systems ahead of their planned public listings. Prominent leaders at these labs have called for a slowdown to address risks first. San Francisco-based Anthropic said in a blog post it identified the incidents after reviewing 141,006 test sessions. REUTERS

Cycle mechanic's daughter from Tripura wins first judo gold

A tribute to late father, who introduced her to the martial art; 'Wish he was alive to see his daughter win,' says mother

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, July 31

WHEN 23-YEAR-OLD Asmita Dey won India's first-ever Commonwealth Games judo gold medal on Friday, it gave her mother something to celebrate just months after losing her husband to a stroke.

Asmita's title in the women's 48kg class was part of a memorable day for the Indian contingent in Glasgow as it was followed by Harsh Singh climbing to the top of the podium with a 10-0 win over Joshua Katz of Australia in the 60kg category and Yamini Mourya's silver in the women's 57kg class. Asmita registered a golden

score win over Canada's Heidi Quach in the final. She had earlier beaten Scotland's Eva Ewing in the quarterfinals via Ippon before winning by Yuko over Summer Shaw of Scotland in the semi-finals.

The family lives in a rented accommodation in the town of Belonia in South Tripura district. Apart from Asmita's mother Munna Patari Dey, her brother Debabrata Dey stays there. The last few months have been tough for the family.

"It was a very hard time for us. Her (Asmita's) father ran a cycle repair shop at the village and our domestic expenses too could not be met. But he always dreamt of giving Asmita every



Asmita with her gold medal after winning the 48kg category. PTI
Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mIjMzg1
monwealth Games gold today," Munna told *The Indian Express* from Belonia.
It was in 2013 that Asmita was taken to the Belonia Vi-

dyapeeth Coaching Center to train under Bina Debnath. For two years, Asmita would stay mostly at Debnath's home. "Even though they were a very poor family, I could sense a determination. There were days when she would not have the bus fare to go back to her village but I helped her with whatever I could. She was very quick in learning the basics and never complained," Debnath shared.

Two years later, Asmita was selected as a residential trainee at Agartala's Tripura Sports School by coach Manik Lal Deb. Along with coach Pranab Saha, the current secretary of the Tripura Judo Association, he would oversee Asmita's training. "When we selected her for the school, I could sense that this girl had a combat sense. Since she was very thin, we had to work on her strength and stamina a lot. Spending time at

the hostel meant that she had proper meals and nutrition. We had to identify the technique that would suit her and worked on her upper body strength. Sometimes, we coaches also had to pool money for her. To see her win gold is our guru dakshina," an emotional Manik Lal Deb told *The Indian Express*.

Steady progress

Medals in junior state as well as school nationals would be followed by Asmita joining the Sports Authority of India's Regional Centre at Bhopal under coach Yashpal Solanki.

In 2023, she won the 48kg title at the junior Asia Cup in Macau and followed that with a silver in the Asian Open in Kuwait. Then there was a bronze at the 2024 Commonwealth Championships and a title at the African Open in Casablanca last year.

"Training under a coach

like Yashpal Solanki helped her a lot. Sometimes sub-junior or junior judokas don't make the transition to youth and senior levels very well, but Asmita did. Whenever she wins a medal at the national or international level, she sends us a picture to show it to young judokas at the Tripura Sports School. It will be the same this time too," Saha told this paper.

In December, when the youngster lost her father, it was a tough time for her. Deb remembers how her coaches at the Tripura Sports School made sure that she made a quick return to the sport.

"She was dejected after her father's death. It took a lot of time for us coaches to ensure that she got over her grief. She is like a daughter for each one of us and I am sure she would be looking to the heavens to show the medal to her father today," says Deb.

Seema's second innings: A mother's journey to CWG glory

After giving birth, 27-year-old struggled to even release the discus; 3 years later, she is on CWG podium

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, July 31

SEEMA KALIRAMANA hurled the discus 58.65m on a cold Glasgow night to win the first major medal of her career, a bronze at the 2026 Commonwealth Games (CWG). On the field, she is India's fourth athletics medallist, but outside it, Seema plays multiple roles.

She is a mother to three-year-old Rudra and is pursuing her PhD in physical education.

"This bronze medal means a lot because it reminds me that every challenge is worth fighting through. The last few years have taught me patience, and moments like these make all the hard work worthwhile," Seema said from Glasgow.

While her release of the discus was smooth during her bronze medal-winning throw, the journey to that moment was anything but.

A promising junior discus thrower, Seema's career hit a roadblock at the senior level when a serious knee injury coincided with the COVID-19 pandemic.

Seema, who was married to Ravinder by that time, planned to have a baby, marking the end of her athletics career. However, the athlete inside her couldn't rest. The pursuit of elite medals, though, came at a cost. In 2023, just 11 months after giving birth to Rudra, she



Seema Kaliramana threw the discus to a distance of 58.65m to win the bronze medal. AP
Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

“Our son won't travel with us to CWG or Asian Games, but that's the sacrifice I have to make for a medal at the world level.”

SEEMA KALIRAMANA,
AFTER WINNING BRONZE MEDAL

stepped back into the throwing pit at Bhim Stadium in Bhubaneswar. It was far from the comeback she had imagined. For the first few days, she was unable to even release the discus.

It took her almost two years to return to active competition, with her husband Ravinder, a former national-level thrower himself, helping her regain

confidence through a carefully planned training regime.

"It was very tough getting back to the field as I was unable to even release the discus properly. But I think the motivation and mentoring of my husband (Ravinder) helped me get back to my normal strength and then improve further," Seema had told *The Indian Express* before leaving for Glasgow.

"My first competition after motherhood was in 2024, where I threw 57.19m to win the Inter State National Championships," Seema, who is backed by IIS, said.

"I could see the potential in her. Despite her knee injury, the technique was fine. So, the next day of marriage I asked her if she is interested and as she said yes, our journey started," said Ravinder. Since then, Seema

has been on a constant rise, winning multiple national titles and improving her personal best three times. Her consistent performances earned her places in both India's Commonwealth Games and Asian Games squads. Bronze in Glasgow was the reward.

Balancing act

For the husband-wife duo of Seema and Ravinder, balancing elite sport with parenthood has required a support system.

"Our son won't travel with us to CWG or Asian Games, but that's the sacrifice I have to make for a medal at the World level," she said.

"In the start, we struggled to find the balance, but eventually we have figured it out now. We have hardly spent time with our son Rudra as he spends

time with his grandparents from both sides. Our families have been extremely supportive in our quest for sporting excellence," Ravinder chimed in.

Seema, who is pursuing a PhD from the Department of Physical Education at Chaudhary Bansi Lal University (CBLU), Bhiwani, treats her academic work as a useful distraction. "The best part is I'm doing a PhD in physical education. It comes as a healthy distraction. I get to know about the biomechanics of the body. That helps a lot, and as I learn more, the results come more quickly," Seema explained.

More than the medal, Seema hoped her journey could break the myth that motherhood ends a sporting career.

"A lot of female athletes have reached out to me after my consistent performances. Some of them even joke that marriage is important, as your performance came after that only," laughed Seema.

"I think it is important that people realise that motherhood is just a phase. Athletes can return to sport easily after having a baby with the right support system."

Bronze in Glasgow may be Seema's first major international medal, but for the discus thrower, the bigger victory is personal - proving that motherhood and elite sport can co-exist.

Relay team qualifies

Led by national record holder Vishal TK, the Indian mixed 4x400m relay team booked a spot in the final finishing seventh overall in the round one heat races.

They clocked 3:20.98 to take the fourth spot in Heat 2 to sneak into the final.